



Hindustan Times

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Let July 20 probe kick off: SC on plea to widen remit

Utkarsh Anand

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday said the five-member high-powered enquiry committee (HPEC), headed by its former judge Justice R Subhash Reddy, should be allowed to conduct its independent inquiry into allegations of excessive use of force during the July 20 protest in Delhi, even as petitioners sought its reconstitution and a wider probe into the alleged role of Union home minister Amit Shah and some other senior government and police functionaries.

The matter was mentioned before Chief Justice of India Surya Kant by senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan, who sought an early listing of an application filed by the petitioners seeking reconstitution of the committee. The CJI said the application would be listed.

"Whoever will work, they will work under the direct supervision of this court. We have not disposed of the matter and will monitor everything," said the CJI.

The court also urged the petitioners to allow the committee to begin its work and raise any concerns before the court as the inquiry progresses.

"Sometimes, we have to also work under some constraints like availability and other factors. You all are also there to assist the committee and can point out to us as and when there are concerns. Let them work and see how they perform," added the CJI.

Solicitor General Tushar continued on 99



Police use water cannons to disperse protesters in Patna on Tuesday.

ANI

COPS: NO REQUEST YET FOR INDIA GATE STIR, WILL PUSH FOR VENUE CHANGE

Jignasa Sinha

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has begun making security arrangements ahead of the CJP's proposed September 5 march, even as officers on Tuesday said the group is yet to seek permission for the protest. An officer said "there is absolutely no possibility that this protest is legal. India Gate is not a designated site." Police said they will push for a venue change.

Student protesters, police clash during Patna march

Avinash Kumar

letters@hindustantimes.com

PATNA: Student protesters demanding a single test for teachers' recruitment in Bihar clashed with police on Tuesday after breaking through barricades while marching towards the governor and chief minister Samrat Choudhary's residences in Patna.

The protesting students planned to picket Choudhary's residence after marching from iconic Gandhi Maidan.

A clutch of student organisations in the state have been opposing the BPSC's move to fill 33,000 teacher posts following a preliminary and main examination.

Police used water cannons to disperse the protesters at JP Golamari at Gandhi Maidan. Police said they used force when protesters broke barricades and allegedly threw stones. Deputy superintendent of police Kamakhya Narayan Singh was among the policemen injured. 99S

SHAH: INDIA NOT A DHARAMSHALA, INFILTRATORS TO BE REMOVED

Neeraj Chauhan

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Union home minister Amit Shah on Tuesday reiterated that India was "not a dharamshala" and that infiltrators threatened the country's security, economy and demographics, as he unveiled a four-pronged border strategy shared with states along the land frontier.

Shah said the government aimed to make India "free of infiltrators in a very short period."

He framed internal security as a prerequisite for a developed India, citing global instability, energy insecurity, supply-chain disruptions, radicalisation and cyber warfare. 99B

KAZAKHSTAN, KENYA, KYRGYZ REPUBLIC EXTRADITION PACTS GET CABINET NOD

Neeraj Chauhan

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Union cabinet chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday approved signing extradition treaties with Kenya, Kazakhstan, and the Kyrgyz Republic, providing a legal framework to combat transnational crimes such as terrorism, drug-trafficking and economic crimes and to seek the repatriation of fugitives from these countries.

Apart from clearing new extradition treaties, the cabinet also gave an ex-post facto approval for signing and ratifying a similar agreement with Seychelles. India and Seychelles signed an extradition treaty during Modi's visit in June. 99S

In China, NSA stresses need for border peace

Rezaul H Laskar

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India on Tuesday emphasised that peace and tranquillity along the border with China are essential for the overall development of bilateral relations, as the special representatives of the two countries met in Beijing to discuss boundary delimitation and transboundary cooperation.

National security adviser Ajit Doval, India's special representative, met his Chinese counterpart, foreign minister Wang Yi, for the 25th round of talks under the mechanism established in 2003 to work out a framework for resolving the dispute over the 3,488km border.

In a social media statement, the Indian embassy said the special representatives "positively reviewed" the momentum in



NSA Ajit Doval with Chinese foreign affairs minister Wang Yi.

bilateral ties, in line with directions from Prime Minister Narendra Modi and president Xi Jinping, and discussed ways to "make progress on boundary delimitation, while sustaining the ongoing work on transboundary cooperation."

The embassy added that both sides discussed expanding bilateral cooperation, maintaining continued on 99

China defends Iran ties after US vows sanctions

BEIJING: Beijing threatened to retaliate against the US and signalled it won't back away from its cooperation with Iran after the Trump administration's latest sanctions targeted businesses in China and Hong Kong.

Speaking on Tuesday at a regular press briefing in Beijing, foreign ministry spokesperson Lin Jian gave China's first official reaction to measures announced by Washington, saying it opposes unilateral sanctions and warning they risk worsening conflicts. The most urgent task is to de-escalate tensions and return to negotiations, he said.

When asked about Beijing's response to the steps taken by the US against Iran and threats made against its trading partners, Lin reiterated that China would act to protect itself.

"China's cooperation with Iran has always been conducted within the international framework and should not be interfered with or undermined," he said. "China is closely monitoring relevant developments and will take all necessary measures to firmly safeguard its own interests."

China buys the bulk of Iran's oil and was its second-largest trading partner in 2025, behind the UAE. 99B

BJP MAY GO SOLO IN 2027 PUNJAB ASSEMBLY POLLS

Smriti Kak Ramachandran

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Senior Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leaders have publicly asserted that the party will fight elections scheduled for early next year in Punjab on its own. However, BJP leaders in the state said that the doors may still be open to erstwhile ally Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD), with at least two senior leaders telling HT that negotiations for an alliance are still going on. On Monday, the party's national general secretary (organisation) BL Santosh, who was on a two-day visit to the state, said the BJP will contest all 117 assembly seats. 99T

SHIFT IN 6 WEEKS, HC TELLS RACE COURSE RD SLUM RESIDENTS

Shruti Kakkar

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Delhi HC Tuesday directed over 350 slum residents living near PM's residence in Race Course area, to shift in six weeks to Savda Gheera, around 35km away, where alternative housing has been arranged.

CENSUS: KHARGE, RAHUL SEEK CHANGE IN CASTE FORMAT

NEW DELHI: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi on Tuesday asked PM Narendra Modi to amend the open-ended format of the ongoing census is using to collect caste data, something that means that the government could end up with hundreds of thousands of caste names. 99S

COUNTRY MUSIC LEGEND DOLLY PARTON DIES AT 80

WASHINGTON: Dolly Parton, the country music icon whose soulful vibrato vocals, poignant songwriting and sparkling costumes defined her rise from the Tennessee mountains to household acclaim with hits like "Jolene", has died. 99Z

IN JASOLA DRAIN } ANOTHER DELHI TRAGEDY

Teen's body found after 3 days; parents waited in rain, dug through garbage to help find him



The drain where 15-year-old Mithun's body was found.

Karn Pratap Singh

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: For 75 hours, Avadesh Kumar and Anita Devi waited beside an open drain in Jasola, through rain and sun, hunger and thirst, hoping against hope that rescuers would pull out their son Mithun alive.

The 15-year-old boy fell into the uncovered drain on Saturday morning while trying to retrieve a kite.

At one point, Kumar started clearing through the mounds of waste with his bare hands and tried to dive into the drain to find him.

Their hopes crumbled on Tuesday afternoon, when disaster response forces found his body 500m downstream, caught in a pile of garbage in the drain, below the Shaheen Bagh Metro station.

"We lost our son due to the government's apathy towards continued on 99

Dabur Chyawanprash
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CM urges EC to extend IT claims, objections window

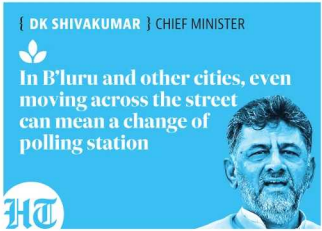
HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Chief minister DK Shivakumar on Tuesday urged the Election Commission of India (ECI) to extend the period to file claims and objections under the special intensive revision in the state, a day after three draft rolls placed around 10.8 million names in the Absent, Shifted, Dead, Duplicate and Others (ASDDO) category.

In a letter to the apex poll body, Shivakumar noted that around one out of every five people in the state were placed in the ASDDO category. "In addition, following publication of the draft rolls on 24 August, verification notices are expected to be issued to roughly 43.81 lakh electors for 'logical discrepancies' or absence of a link to the 2002 roll. In Bengaluru alone, 46.88 lakh electors have been placed under the ASDDO category. This translates into about 15 crore voters in Karnataka facing deletion unless they submit their claims for continuation or correction," wrote the minister.

Shivakumar pointed out that many of those marked 'absent' may be genuine electors who



{ DK SHIVAKUMAR } CHIEF MINISTER

In B'lu and other cities, even moving across the street can mean a change of polling station



were away from home for work, health or other legitimate reasons, when booth level officers (BLOs) visited. Similarly, many electors who moved to a different polling station could not submit forms at their new homes. "In Bengaluru and other cities, even moving across the street can mean a change of polling station. As a result, many genuine voters may face disenfranchisement under the Absent and Others categories and will now have to file Form 6 for inclusion. Their category of voters should be genuine electors who

which are only sent to 'logical discrepancies and unmapped' voters. Therefore, they may not even be aware that their names have been deleted," wrote Shivakumar. He said that the concern heightened in dynamic societies where geographical mobility was routine for many. "Mobility should not translate into disenfranchisement," he added. Shivakumar requested the ECI to consider extending the period for two constables attached to the Sirwar police station in Raichur district, they added.

names are absent from the draft roll, including those in the ASDDO category, to ascertain their status and file claims through Form 6. With no election due in Karnataka in the near future, such an extension is eminently feasible," he said.

The current window for claims and objections is due to close on September 23. The CM noted that this translated into a roughly 45-day window to issue notices and dispose of cases of "logical discrepancies" and unmapped voters. "Giving an elector about a week to respond, followed by a second notice, may place an unreasonable burden on working people, migrants and the elderly... A minimum of three to four weeks should therefore be provided to each elector to respond and furnish the necessary documents," he said.

"The state government stands ready to provide all possible assistance, including mobilising the local administration for gram sabhas and ward committee meetings, undertaking widespread publicity to reach affected voters, and providing any other coordination or logistical support required by the ECI," added the chief minister.

PRAKASH RAJ TO JOIN SEPTEMBER 1 CIVIL CAMPAIGN TO FLAG FLAWS IN S.I.R

Naheed Ataula

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Actor Prakash Raj on Tuesday said that civil society organisations in Bengaluru will hold an "Election Commission Chalo" campaign on September 1 to flag alleged flaws in the conduct of the S.I.R.

He added that the groups, including Eddelu Karnataka, Muslim Muttahida Mahaz, Namma Mata Namma Hakku Vedike, and Active Bengaluru, would also move the courts to seek a halt to the exercise.

Earlier, Raj had uploaded a clip claiming he was marked under ASDDO. However, civic officials said that he was listed as a voter in Shanthinagar as of June 16, when elector lists for the draft roll data was frozen.

bangaloretalkies

Fresh catch from the ocean in Bengaluru



Shoba Narayan

On any given Saturday morning in the tree-lined avenues of Kammanahalli, an observant passerby will notice a distinct ritual playing out near Mangalore Fish Stall, known for sourcing fish from the Konkani coast. Here, you find shoppers, male and female who inspect fresh mackerel (*bangda*), kingfish (*anjali*), pomfret (*manji*), prawns and crabs with a sharp eye. They are looking for specific indicators of freshness: bright, unclouded eyes, firm silver flanks that spring back under pressure, and the faint, sweet scent of the open ocean.

There are two types of fish-eaters: those that love freshwater fish like the Bengal, and those who love fish from the ocean like those from the Konkani coast. The Konkani-speaking Saraswat Brahmin community is somewhat of an anomaly, much like the Bengali Brahmins. Their cuisine is pescovegetarian, with subtle grays, distinct spices, souring agents, and a love for coconut. "For us, coconut is the primary ingredient," says Kalpana Nayak, a Goud Saraswat Brahmin (GSB) who lives in Sahakar Nagar. "We need one coconut a day in our cooking, starting with our morning chutneys and going into our ghashis and sweets."

Met Kalpana because her husband, Dr. Rabinendra Nayak, is a reputed orthodontist in Bengaluru, and treated my children. He also happens to be one of the nicest and more generous human beings, offering free treatment and braces for the underprivileged. Through the Nayaks, I got an intro into the cuisine that originated in the Saraswati river.

GSBs and their sister community, the Chitrapur Saraswat Brahmins (CSB), more commonly just called Saraswat Brahmins, are prominent in the city and host many celebrities. Deepika Padukone, Guru Maya Rao, and Nandan Nilekani, for instance, are CSBs, while the Kamaths who founded Zerodha, Girish Karnad, Ananth and Shankar Nag, and Vittal Mallaya all belong to the CSB community.

Saraswat cuisine however, is not well known in Bengaluru. When I asked Tara Kini, a famous musician who is a GSB for restaurants serving the cuisine, she came up with exactly one name: Namma Kudla in Malleshwaram. "Most of us eat Konkani food at home, and so when we go out, we want to eat other food," says Tara with a laugh.

There are two types of Saraswats: the strictly vegetarian ones like Tara and the ones who enjoy fish. Saraswat fish curries are milder and more delicate in flavour compared to the robust, chilli-heavy red curries of their coastal Bunt or Mangalorean Catholic neighbors. Coconut milk and finely ground coconut paste form the base for their fish dishes. Their vegetarian repertoire begins with *dalitaya*, a simple, deeply comforting dal made from yellow split pigeon peas (*tuvar dal*), simmered with slit green chillies, and finished with a crackling tempering of mustard seeds, curry leaves, and a generous pinch of high-grade asafoetida (*hing*). This dish serves as the emotional baseline for every GSB home in Bengaluru. "Rice, dal and a curry (which Konkans call upkari, are what we call as our kuladev: sheetha dal upkari," says Tara. Konkani heritage involves one of the most remarkable food migrations in South Asian history. Lore and history traces them to the banks of the ancient, mythical Saraswati river. When the river dried up around the 2nd millennium BCE, a community of people initiated a massive, centuries-long Southern migration. They settled in the territories of the Keladi and Maratha of Gomantak (Goa). Once strictly vegetarian, the abundance of seafood all around caused them to adapt and sample these new foods by classifying them as Jala Kashi or "vegetables of the sea."

In fact, one cloud kitchen that serves seafood dishes in Bengaluru's Kodigehalli is called Jhalke's coastal chattr. In the 16th century, following the arrival of the Portuguese and the enforcement of the Goa Inquisition starting in 1560, thousands of Saraswat families packed their bronze vessels, stone grinders and their family deities (Kula Devatas like Mangeshi, Venkateswara, and Shantadurga) into wooden boats. Sailing south along the Konkani line, they sought refuge in the territories of the Keladi and Maratha rulers of coastal Karnataka—settling in the port towns of Karwar, Honnavar, Bhatkal, Udipi, and Mangalore.

When the rapid industrial expansion, banking boom, and administrative consolidation of Bengaluru drew thousands of coastal migrants inland during the early to mid-20th century, the Saraswat Brahmins moved once more. They brought with them their complete, self-contained food universe. Theirs was actually a coastal larval heavily dependent on coconut, wild souring agents, indigenous peppers, and sea fish. This maritime tropical cuisine was adapted to the chilly, high-altitude climate of the Deccan plateau.

Today, Konkans thrive in Bengaluru and buy their ingredients at stores scattered throughout Bengaluru. Visit one to sample their delicious dishes. I'd recommend starting with the *pathrode*.

(Shoba Narayan is a Bengaluru-based award-winning author. She is also a freelance contributor who writes about art, food, fashion and travel for various publications)

CD takes over probe into Hanur killings

Coovercolly Indresh and S Vijay Karthik

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU/CHENNAI: The state government on Tuesday transferred the probe into the killing of three people from neighbouring Tamil Nadu by forest personnel in the Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary in Channarayana's Hanur taluk on August 14 to the Criminal Investigation Department (CID), a day after their most recent reports revealed that they were shot from a "close range" and had similar bullet entry wounds.

DGP MB Saleem ordered that the four cases lodged following the killing be transferred to the CID. The post-mortem reports, which HT has seen, said that while bullet entry marks were almost similar in all the bodies, there were slight variations in the exit wounds.

"This variance may be because of the direction from where the bullet was fired," said a forensic expert. The report also records injuries caused by shotgun pellets. "Small lead pellets from the shotgun entered the body and penetrated the liver and inner abdominal lining," it said.

On the issue of death, the forensic records that the victims died due to "excessive blood loss and shock."

Officials said the CID is expected to examine the post-mortem findings along with the ballistic evidence to determine the distance from which the shots were fired and whether forest personnel followed prescribed procedures while opening fire. The ballistic report is yet to be submitted to the police.

Meanwhile, in Tamil Nadu assembly, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) claimed

OFFICIALS SAID CID IS EXPECTED TO EXAMINE THE POST-MORTEM FINDINGS ALONG WITH BALLISTIC EVIDENCE

that the autopsy reports revealed that the victims were tortured before being shot from a close range.

Raising the issue in the state Assembly, Leader of Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin claimed that the post-mortem report of the deceased Anthony Samy, John Rose Peter, and Kumar indicated that they were "tortured and shot at very close range."

"The three had severe injuries, including broken bones. This was brutal killing. I would like to know what action this government has taken to condemn this. At least has the government sought an explanation from Karnataka government," Udhayanidhi asked.

The Tamil Nadu government and all opposition parties have maintained a demand for a CBI probe into the case, which the state government has consistently refused to know.

He sought to know if Tamil Nadu CM C Joseph Vijay raised the issue at the Southern Zone Tamil Nadu CM meeting or whether Tamil Nadu's condemnation was personally conveyed to the counterpart DK Shivakumar.

He called for measures to provide necessary legal assistance to the three affected families.

Speaker J C D Prabhakar said that a state minister had already raised a query when the issue was raised on August 18. Nevertheless, the law minister would give a detailed reply soon.

Four cops suspended over delay in missing woman case probe

RAICHUR: Four police personnel have been suspended over the gang rape and murder of a 21-year-old woman after they allegedly failed to act promptly when her family reported her missing, police officers said on Tuesday.

Those suspended were two head constables and two constables attached to the Sirwar police station in Raichur district, they added.

State to establish AI CoE at IIT campus in Raichur: Minister

BENGALURU: Karnataka will establish an AI CoE of Excellence at the IIT campus in Raichur worth ₹12 crore to promote industrial growth, minister MB Patil said on Tuesday, while addressing the conference, "AI for Manufacturing: Building a Future-Ready Karnataka".

"To effectively tackle the prevailing rainfall deficit and pre-empt severe water scarcity, we have decided to take up cloud seeding on priority," he said at a press briefing, adding that three specialised committees for the project are being formed, which include the Monitoring Committee, Technical Committee, and Field Operation & Evaluation Committee. The panels will conduct initial technical assessments, after which cloud seeding operations and field evaluation will commence.

Two high-level preparatory meetings have already taken place, and specific operational directives have been issued to department secretaries, he said. Karnataka has previously undertaken cloud seeding on three occasions, recording an average success rate between 18% and 20%, he said.

The inspection team comprised District Sessions Judge and DLSA President Chandrasekhar C. KLSIA Member Secretary Shashidhar Shetty, Public Relations Officer Balasubramani, member Dr Mohan Rao Nalwade and DLSA Member Secretary Anand M.

According to Karnataka Director General of Police (Prison) Alok Kumar, Hussain was referred by the visiting doctor at the prison to MIMS Hospital, where the doctor advised that he be admitted.

Responding to reports that he was responding with a woman, the officer said, "That is not our responsibility. That is the responsibility of the escort provided by the district police," adding that they were taking action against the TR personnel.

He said the accused has been sent back to judicial custody.

33-yr-old killed after speeding car rams into motorcycle: Cops

BENGALURU: A 33-year-old biker was killed after a speeding car rams into his motorcycle at a traffic signal here, police said.

The incident occurred on Monday morning on Kaggadasapura Main Road in Vignana Nagar, they said. The deceased was identified as a barber shop who was on his way to work when the accident occurred.

Dasara elephant pooja



Five elephants — Dhananjaya, Prashantha, Gopi, Sirrama and Kaveri — prepare to leave the Dubare camp on Tuesday as part of Mysuru Dasara preparations.

HT PHOTO

CWMA upholds Cauvery water release order

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) on Tuesday upheld the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee's (CWRC) recommendation directing Karnataka to ensure a flow of 9,000 cuses of water to Tamil Nadu for 15 days.

The decision was taken at the 56th meeting of the CWMA held in Delhi under the chairmanship of S K Halder. Officials from Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Puducherry, Andhra Pradesh and Kerala participated in the meeting.

THE DECISION WAS TAKEN AT THE 56TH MEETING OF THE CWMA HELD IN DELHI WITH OFFICIALS FROM 5 STATES PRESENT

Prashant M Wadner, Secretary, Water Resources Department, Tamil Nadu, along with Thiru Subramanian, Chairman of the Cauvery Technical Cell, attended the meeting.

The meeting was held following the Supreme Court's direction

to the Tamil Nadu government on Monday to raise before the CWMA its stance over the release of its proportionate share of Cauvery water by Karnataka.

According to the CWRC, 11.6 TMC of water has to be released over 15 days. We requested them to reduce it to 6,000 cuses.

"Tamil Nadu argued for increasing the release to 28 TMC. After all discussions in the meeting, the CWMA reiterated the recommendation of the CWRC," Karnataka officer Gaur Gupta said.

At its 141st meeting on Monday, the CWRC had directed

Karnataka to release water from its reservoirs and ensure a flow of 9,000 cuses at the Billigundlu border point. The flow has to be maintained continuously for 15 days, during which Tamil Nadu is expected to receive approximately 11.66 TMC of water."

The release is expected to benefit Kaveri cultivation and meet Tamil Nadu's drinking water requirements.

Earlier, the CWRC had directed Karnataka to release 12,000 cuses of water daily to Tamil Nadu for 15 days from August 14.

The CWMA had subsequently upheld that decision.

Renukaswamy, a Chitrapur resident, was allegedly abducted and brought to Bengaluru before being killed in June 2024. His body was found near a drain in the city. Darshan and several others were arrested.

{ RENUKASWAMY MURDER CASE }

Court allows accuse Pradosh's petition to turn approver in case

Coovercolly Indresh

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: A Bengaluru court has allowed Pradosh S Rao, an associate of actor Darshan and among the accused in the Renukaswamy murder case, to turn an approver.

The 59th City Civil and Sessions Court accepted Pradosh's application to become an approver after examining his request and permitted him to surrender before the court. The court also ordered that he be kept in separate judicial custody.

Pradosh is among the 17 accused and is alleged to have been involved in the 35-year-old Renukaswamy was assaulted. The court made it clear that

THE COURT SAID PRADOSH WILL FACE ADDITIONAL CHARGES IF ANYTHING IN HIS ACCOUNT IS FOUND TO BE FALSIFIED

and facing additional legal action for giving false testimony. People aware of the matter said Pradosh's statement may provide details about the events leading to Renukaswamy's death, the alleged assault and the involvement of other accused persons.

To be sure, the court's decision does not by itself establish the allegations against him or the other accused. Pradosh's account will have to be tested against other evidence available in the case.

Renukaswamy, a Chitrapur resident, was allegedly abducted and brought to Bengaluru before being killed in June 2024. His body was found near a drain in the city. Darshan and several others were arrested.

GOVERNOR ORDERS SUSPENSION OF KPSC HEAD AFTER CABINET ADVICE

Coovercolly Indresh

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Governor Thawarchand Gehlot on Tuesday ordered the suspension of Karnataka Public Service Commission (KPSC) chairman Shivashankarappa S Sahukar, acting on the advice and recommendation of the state cabinet.

The order was issued from Lok Bhawan under Article 317(2) of the Constitution and will remain in force until further orders from the President. It follows the state high court's intervention last week, which had quashed an earlier suspension order against Sahukar.

The Governor had previously suspended the KPSC chairman without a recommendation from the state Cabinet. Sahukar argued before the high court, that the suspension was constitutionally invalid.

The court observed that the governor was required to act on the advice of the cabinet in the matter and set aside the earlier suspension order. Following the court ruling, the state cabinet met on August 21 and recommended Sahukar's suspension to the Governor. The latest order has not been issued based on that recommendation.

The development comes amid serious allegations surrounding the functioning of the KPSC and the selection process for government posts. Sahukar has faced allegations that he had helped facilitate the alleged irregular selection of his Industrial Extension Officers.

Govt official facing graft charges found living with woman at hospital's spl ward

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

MANDYA: An undertrial government official, who was admitted to a special ward at MIMS Hospital here for treatment, was found with a woman during a surprise inspection by the Karnataka State Legal Services Authority (KLSLA).

The KLSLA team conducted an inspection at MIMS Hospital on Monday evening, officials said on Tuesday.

According to officials, during the inspection, it was found that the Assistant Director of Land Records (ADLR) survey supervisor Mahamud Hussain, who is an under trial in a corruption case, had been admitted to the Mandya Institute of Medical Sciences (MIMS) Hospital, where he

OFFICIALS SAID THE ACCUSED DID NOT HAVE ANY SERIOUS HEALTH ISSUE TO WARRANT TREATMENT AND ALSO DID NOT SEEK A COURT NOOD

was undergoing treatment since August 2.

They said there was no court permission and he also had no serious health condition warranting such treatment. During the inspection, he was found to be staying there with a woman in the same room of the hospital ward, they said.

Responding to a question if an inquiry from the police has been

initiated into the matter, a police officer said, "Action is being taken against those who were deployed there as escorts and also against those who were responsible for the entry (of the woman)." According to officials, Hussain, an officer arrested during the Lokayukta raid at the Assistant Director of Land Records (ADLR) office in Srirangapatna, was remanded to judicial custody by a court on July 3, a day after the raid led by the Lokayukta sleuths.

Hussain allegedly entered the Srirangapatna Taluk Land Records office illegally and was accused of helping in Aakarbandh (demarcation of land) work, digitisation of records and creation of fake documents.

The inspection team comprised District Sessions Judge

and DLSA President Chandrasekhar C. KLSIA Member Secretary Shashidhar Shetty, Public Relations Officer Balasubramani, member Dr Mohan Rao Nalwade and DLSA Member Secretary Anand M.

According to Karnataka Director General of Police (Prison) Alok Kumar, Hussain was referred by the visiting doctor at the prison to MIMS Hospital, where the doctor advised that he be admitted.

Responding to reports that he was responding with a woman, the officer said, "That is not our responsibility. That is the responsibility of the escort provided by the district police," adding that they were taking action against the TR personnel.

He said the accused has been sent back to judicial custody.

SOUTH REGION

TK, Open trade barks over Parandur project clearance

S Vijay Karthik
letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI: The previous Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) government did not receive the environmental clearance for the Parandur airport project and even the environmental impact assessment was not conducted for this project, the Tamil Nadu government said on Tuesday.

Minister for energy resources and law CTR Nirmal Kumar, while making his comments during the special calling attention motion in the Tamil Nadu assembly, said with the current work being taken at the existing airport in Meenambakkam, the completion of Terminal 3 and the Terminal 5, the capacity would be enhanced from the existing 30 million passengers to 55 million passengers, annually.

Giving a detailed picture on the reasons behind the government's decision to scrap the second airport in Parandur about 60 km west of Chennai, Kumar said, "for this Parandur airport 5,840 acre land was required and out of that 3,774 acre were private lands. Out of this 3,774 acre lands, 2,681 acre were agricultural lands. The land classified as government land was just 1,972 acre."

However, in that 1,972 acre land which was government land, 1,558 acre comprise of water bodies and streams, he



CTR Nirmal Kumar and Thangam Thennarasu

said. "The DMK claimed that 90% of the land was acquired for developing the Parandur airport project. But, that is not true. So far only 1,802 acres land have been acquired which is 48% of the total land required, the rest of the land has not been acquired," Kumar said.

Referring to the land belonging to the Ekanapuram and neighbouring 12 villages who have been opposing this Parandur airport project for more than a year, Kumar said, "not even a single cent of land has been acquired from them."

On the development of existing airport at Meenambakkam, he said the current capacity of the existing airport is 30 million.

"With the completion of work on the Terminal 3, it will add another 5 million passenger

capacity taking the overall capacity of the Airport to 35 million passengers," he said.

With the chief minister's announcement of upgrading the Chennai Airport with Terminal 5 in North West region of the airport, Kumar said, "We will be able to serve an additional 20 million passengers per year taking the overall capacity to 55 million passengers annually." He cited that the Bengaluru airport was currently handling only 45 million passengers a year.

Kumar also hit out at the DMK regime, stating, "They claim the environmental clearance has been obtained. But that is not true at all. Even an Environmental Impact Assessment was not conducted for the Parandur airport. Without doing that Environmental Clearance cannot be obtained."

Despite the project was announced five years ago, it did not take off because of the presence of waterbodies and agricultural lands, he said.

Responding to the comments of Kumar, DMK MLA (Thiruchuli) and former minister Thangam Thennarasu said, "When the DMK was in power, it did not directly go to Parandur site just like that and decided the land. You may ask the officials for this."

Thennarasu said his team took up several visits across Chennai and neighbourhood regions.

"We visited various places and since east of Chennai lies the sea, we cannot go in that direction. If you go north of Chennai, areas like Manali and Ennore are industrial estates. If we go south toward Sholinganallur, it falls directly in line with the Tambaram Air Force base, so it could not be accommodated within its airspace. None of these areas could be used and therefore Airports Authority of India did not accept these locations and rejected them," he said.

However, Thennarasu said that after doing a comparison study of Panpur and Parandur located on the west, Parandur was decided. "Parandur was selected based on technical feasibility. The Ministry of Civil Aviation also gave approval for Parandur," he said.

Thennarasu clarified that

there was no "hidden political motive" behind the identification of land in Parandur.

Noting that the government has scrapped the Parandur airport project, Thennarasu said, "You (the TVK government) talk about USD 15 trillion economy by 2036 but on the other hand you are taking steps against your stance (by scrapping Parandur airport)".

Meanwhile, former chief minister and All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) MLA Edappadi K Palaniswami responding to the comments of the minister, asked what would the government do with the acquired 48% of the land from the farmers with the airport project being scrapped at Parandur.

Responding to this, minister for industries S Keerthana said, "Alternative industrial projects will be implemented on the acquired land without affecting the people. Through this industrial growth, employment opportunities and economic development will occur in this region."

Keerthana also clarified that two water canals were present and they were directly linked with the Adyar River and the Chembarambakkam Lake in Chennai.

Chief minister C Joseph Vijay on Monday announced that his government would drop the Parandur airport project.

Row over pvt properties in 'gana prohibited list

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: The inclusion of thousands of private properties under Section 22A of the Registration Act, 1908, prohibiting transactions of these properties kicks up a major political controversy in Telangana, with the opposition accusing the Congress government of turning the provision to harass common people.

The state government, however, has defended the restrictions, saying they are essential to protect public land and prevent fraudulent registrations. At the same time, it has assured to rectify mistakes, if any, in the registration of genuine land transactions.

According to a senior revenue department official, Section 22A of the Registration Act, 1908, empowers the government to identify certain categories of properties whose registration should be prohibited. "The objective is to prevent the illegal sale or alienation of government, assigned, disputed or other protected properties," he said.

The prohibited category can include government waste lands, assigned lands, properties belonging to municipalities and government institutions, endowment and Waqf properties, surplus lands under the Urban Land Ceiling Act, forest lands, lands covered by the protective provisions of Regulation 1 of 1970 in tribal areas, and properties under court orders or disputes.

"Once a survey number is included in the prohibited list, sub-registrars generally cannot

THE STATE GOVT DEFENDED THE RESTRICTIONS, SAYING THEY ARE ESSENTIAL TO PROTECT PUBLIC LAND AND PREVENT BOGUS REGISTRATIONS

register transactions involving that property," he said.

People familiar with the matter said while undertaking changes in the land registration portal-Dharami in previous regime, which has now been replaced by Bhu Bharati, thousands of genuine private properties, including decades-old residential layouts, apartments and lands that had previously received clearances from government agencies, were brought under Section 22-A without adequate verification.

For the last one month, the state revenue department has been receiving complaints from property owners that the restrictions are preventing them from selling or registering their properties and, in some cases, leaving them to discover the restrictions after paying registration charges and completing much of the transaction process.

The issue has particularly affected several areas in and around Hyderabad, including parts of Medchal-Malkajgiri, Rangareddy, Sangareddy and Hyderabad districts. Several localities, including Jubilee Hills, Banjara Hills, Kukatpally, Miyapur, Kondapur, Bachupally

and Nizampet, have reportedly witnessed complaints from property owners facing difficulties with registration," the official quoted has said.

The opposition leader Rashtra Samithi (BRS) has taken up a state-wide agitation against this inclusion of thousands of acres of land under the prohibited list. Senior BRS leader and former finance minister T Harish Rao demanded a judicial probe by a sitting judge into the issue besides "demanding a white paper on the issue."

Speaking to reporters on Tuesday at Shapur Nagar, where the locals have complained against inclusion of their properties under Section 22-A, Harish Rao said the government had erred by including private, registered and patta lands in the prohibited list.

The revenue minister hit back at the BRS, saying the primary objective of Section 22-A was to prevent government land from being diverted for private and real-estate interests.

"The government had recently protected 522 acres of government land including 22 acres in two revenue villages in Narsapur of Medak district and more than 400 acres elsewhere," he said, speaking to reporters in the secretariat on Monday. The minister alleged that large tracts of government land had been diverted for private purposes during the previous regime.

Keerthana also clarified that in the site identified at Parandur two water canals were present and they were directly linked with the Adyar River and the Chembarambakkam Lake in Chennai.

Fight aggressively in next local body polls: Jagan to party workers

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: YSR Congress party president and former Andhra Pradesh chief minister YS Jagan Mohan Reddy Tuesday called upon party leaders and cadre to fight aggressively in the forthcoming local body elections.

Addressing party coordinators, constituency in-charges and other leaders at the party's central office at Tadepalli, Jagan said there was a strong anti-incumbency against all ruling coalition government led by Telugu Desam Party (TDP) across all parts of the state. "We need to take the fight to the voters and see that they are not misled by the ruling coalition government led by TDP," he said.

He said the coalition government led by the ruling coalition during its two years in office and expressed confidence that the



YS Jagan Mohan Reddy

YSRCP would win if the elections were conducted in a free and fair manner. He urged party leaders to ensure that the YSRCP fields candidates for every seat and does not allow elections to go uncontested. "We will not allow any forced unanimous elections anywhere in the state," he said, stressing that party candidates should be in the fray so that voters could make their choice.

He called for training party workers in the use of the Jagan 20 app and asked leaders who were not active on social media to familiarise themselves with the platforms.

HC warns of imposing cost on Vijay for delay in election case response

Ayesha Arvind
letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI: The Madras high court on Tuesday warned that it will impose costs on Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay and minister Aadhar Arjuna after their counsel sought an adjournment to file applications seeking rejection of election petitions challenging their victories in the 2026 assembly elections.

Justice V Lakshminarayana said the court was "not concerned about the personalities involved" and only wanted to ensure that the election petitions were decided within six months. "I am not bothered about the personalities. You people say that election cases are not being decided. But then you are asking time. Election petitions are to be disposed of within six months," the judge said.

However, after senior advocates Maslamani and Srivath Sridevan, who appeared for the chief minister and Arjuna, assured the court that the appli-



C Joseph Vijay and Aadhar Arjuna

cations will be filed within a day, the judge refrained from imposing costs and adjourned the hearing to August 27.

The court had admitted the election petitions in July challenging Vijay's victory from the Perambur and Tiruchirappalli (East) constituencies. It had also admitted petitions challenging Aadhar Arjuna's victory from the Villavakkam constituency.

While permitting private notice in the cases, Justice Lakshminarayana had stressed that election petitions must be decided as expeditiously as possible and within six months.

CM Vijay and Arjuna later

informed the court that they intended to file applications seeking rejection of the election petitions. At the previous hearing, the court had granted them two weeks' time and directed them to ensure that the applications were filed within the stipulated period.

When the matter came up on Tuesday, their advocates said the applications were ready but the parties had not yet signed them due to the ongoing assembly session.

They assured the court that the applications will be filed within two days and requested not to impose costs.

Considering the request, the court adjourned the hearing and refrained from imposing costs for the time being. Four election petitions challenge CM Vijay's victories. Three of those challenge his election from Perambur, while one challenges his victory from Tiruchirappalli (East). Two petitions challenge Aadhar Arjuna's victory from Villavakkam.

Auto-rickshaw overturns after hitting bus



Traffic police personnel and a passerby try to lift an auto-rickshaw that overturned after hitting a TSRTC bus on the Tank Bund road in Hyderabad on Tuesday.

{ INTERVIEW } PC VISHNUNADH, KERALAM TOURISM MINISTER

'We will lure travellers using Ayurveda, adventure tourism'

Vishnu Varma
letters@hindustantimes.com

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: On the eve of the Onam festival and the tourism department's weeklong celebrations, HT caught up with PC Vishnunadh, the Kerala tourism and culture minister, to talk about the challenges and positives in both sectors. Excerpts:

It's the first annual Onam celebrations under the new UDF government. What's new this time compared to previous years?

"Onam is a great time for tourists to visit Kerala. That's the message we want to send. We conducted a strong campaign, especially on social media. This time, during the week-long festival in Thiruvananthapuram, we are hosting Kerala's own art forms like Theyyam, Padayani and Tholpavikali, apart from music and dance performances. We have over 8,000 artists performing at various venues across the state. In 3,000 venues alone, we have 3,000 artists at over 35 venues.

Could you list out the challenges relating to the two departments you're in charge of - culture and



tourism - since you took over in May?

"The challenges are basic. For example, several of our high-profile destinations like Kochi, beach, Munnar, Alappuzha, houseboat terminal and Fort Kochi. It can have a negative effect on travellers and harm our marketing efforts. The second challenge is the absence of proper lighting at these destinations. Travellers should be able to come out and walk safely. In the culture department, there are only 27 staff at the culture directorate to manage all the cultural activities across the state. We don't even have a proper permanent office. We have announced that both tourism and cinema fields will be given 'industry' status. It will help both sectors grow."

Kochi-Munnar-Alappuzha circuit continues to bring substantial tourism, whereas other destinations, especially in north Kerala, remain underutilised. What do you plan to do about this?

"The destinations on the Kochi

-Munnar -Alappuzha route are beyond their carrying capacities. My perspective is that we have to look beyond just adding more tourists to attract travellers. In Kerala, we have Ayurveda and we are the home of authentic Ayurveda practices. A traveller coming here for Ayurveda treatment can also get a glimpse of our monsoon, our cultural practices, our food etc. Another strength is our medical value tourism. We also offer big scope for adventure tourism. The unique aspect about Kerala is that a traveller can experience forests, backwaters and the sea in the same trip. For the government to plan to integrate our culture with the annual tourism calendar. We will lure travellers using Ayurveda, wellness, adventure tourism

The Justice Hema panel report had made several recommendations for women safety, but were hardly implemented by the previous government. Will you do it?

"Certainly, we will examine the suggestions and take necessary steps. Film actors' body AMMA is going through a major internal crisis. Will the government intervene to sort out issues within it? Right now, it's an internal issue. For the government to interfere in its functioning is a moral and legal wrangle. But if there is a police complaint or an issue that the culture department has to address, we will step in."

CHENNAI COUPLE ACCUSED OF ₹1-CR CHEATING HELD AFTER 10 YEARS

S Vijay Karthik
letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI: The central crime branch police on Tuesday arrested a Chennai couple who had been absconding for over a decade after allegedly cheating a resident of more than ₹1 crore, police said.

According to the couple, Dhanraj, 49, and his wife D Rajalakshmi, 41, met V Jagan Mohan Reddy, a common friend in 2010 promised high returns to him through a real estate business which the couple was allegedly running.

Believing the couple, Jagan initially invested an amount of ₹58.12 lakh in the investments between 2010 and 2011. In addition, he paid a sum of ₹22 lakh as chit fund money to D Rajalakshmi and another ₹57 lakh that was demanded by her under various reasons, police added.

"The total amount received by the couple was ₹1.05 crore from V Jagan. However, after collecting the money, the couple went missing," the police said.

A complaint was filed on April 20, 2015, by Jagan and the case was being investigated by the Central Crime Branch, Chennai since then. A special team was formed under inspector L Sarojini, with the use of modern technology, the special team arrested the couple who have been absconding for over 10 years. Both accused were produced before the court on Tuesday and remanded to judicial custody, the police added.

17 fall ill after having foul food in TN school

S Vijay Karthik
letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI: Seventeen students at a government-aided school in Poonamallee, Tiruvallur district fell ill on Monday after eating breakfast, which was allegedly contaminated by a dead lizard, police said.

The senior secondary students who already consumed the food, which was allegedly contaminated by a dead lizard, police said.

According to the police, one of the teachers had noticed the

dead lizard in the food and immediately alerted the children, however, several fell ill.

17 students were hospitalised in the district government hospital for treatment, they said.

An official said while 15 students have been discharged and two others will be discharged today. "Currently, the two children are under observation. They were discharged tomorrow once they are completely recovered" an official, who asked not to be named, told HT, adding, "Notice has been issued to the contractor who provided the food and action will be taken as per the tender conditions."

Swaminathan institute to get YSR Award 2026

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: The M S Swaminathan Research Foundation (MSRF), based in Chennai, has been selected for the Y S Rajasekhara Reddy Award for 2026 in recognition of its pioneering and enduring contribution to Indian agriculture, food security, sustainable development and rural livelihoods.

The award, carrying a cash prize of ₹25 lakh, was instituted by Hyderabad-based YSR & KVP Foundation, established in 2025 by former Rajya Sabha member and former advisor to the

Andhra Pradesh government K V P Ramachander Rao in memory of former chief minister Y S Rajasekhara Reddy.

"The MSRF carries forward the legacy of the late M S Swaminathan, a Bharat Ratna awardee whose scientific leadership played a pivotal role in India's Green Revolution and the country's transition from food scarcity to self-reliance," the former MP noted. The award will be presented to MSRF at a ceremony at the Constitution Club of India in New Delhi on September 2. The inaugural award recognising the pioneering work of Subhash Palekar.

5 of family found dead in Shrisailam lodge, police suspect suicide

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: Five members of a family were found dead in a lodge room in the temple town of Shrisailam in Andhra Pradesh's Nandyal district on Tuesday, with police suspecting the incident as a suicide linked to financial difficulties.

The deceased were identified as a 36-year-old man, his three sons, aged 33, 45 and 50, and his 15-year-old nephew, who were residents of Bathalappalli in Sri Sathula district.

Atmakar deputy superintendent of police (DSP) Ramani Naik told reporters that the family members were found dead in a room of Vaddera Satram, a lodge run by the Vaddera community in Shrisailam. "One man and a minor were found dead in the hall, while the three women were found dead in the bathroom," he said. Quoting the lodge management, DSP Naik said the family checked into the room on July 28. "All five had been staying in the room and had a daily rent of ₹800. The lodge authorities said they had asked the family to vacate after two days, as prolonged stays were not permitted. However, the family reportedly told the management that they were unwell and continued to stay," he said.

Lodge staff told police that the family had not moved any of the family members for the past three days. "On Tuesday, the lodge

THE DECEASED INVOLVE A MAN, HIS THREE SISTERS AND HIS 15-YEAR-OLD NEPHEW, WITH POLICE SAYING THE FAMILY WAS FACING FINANCIAL DIFFICULTIES

staff noticed a strong foul smell from the room and went to check on the occupants. After finding the bodies, they alerted the Shrisailam town police," Naik said.

Preliminary inquiries revealed that the 36-year-old man was unmarried, while two of his sisters were living at their parental home after separating from their husbands. "We have learnt that the family had been facing financial difficulties. We suspect these problems may have led to the deaths," Naik said.

Expressing concerns, Shrisailam temple authorities alleged that the Vaddera Satram management had violated accommodation rules. They directed all private accommodation to strictly follow the prescribed rules while allowing rooms.

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Students clash with cops in Patna, several injured

Avinash Kumar
letters@hindustantimes.com

PATNA: Student protesters demanding a single test for teachers' recruitment in Bihar clashed with police on Tuesday after breaking through barricades while marching towards the governor and chief minister Samrat Choudhary's residences in Patna.

The protesting students — mostly aspirants for Teachers' Recruitment Exams to be conducted by Bihar Public Service Commission (BPSC) next month — under the banner of leftist Students' Federation of India (SFI) and Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI) planned to picket Choudhary's residence after marching from iconic Gandhi Maidan. Several protesters were detained when the marchers reached Dak Bangalou crossing. The student organisations have been opposing the BPSC's move to fill 33,000 teacher posts following a preliminary and main examination.

Tight security arrangements were in place from Gandhi Maidan to the CM's residence, with several police deploying anti-riot gear. Rapid Action Force and CRPF along with the state police in central Patna ahead of the march.

Police used water cannons to disperse the protesters at JP Golamari at Gandhi Maidan. Police said they were used when protesters broke barricades and allegedly threw stones. Deputy superintendent of police Kamakhya Narayan Singh was among the policemen injured.

The protesters also scuffled with police personnel at Dak Bangalou roundabout. One student suffered head injuries, and another fell unconscious.

"We repeatedly urged the cops to maintain peace and told them that we will help them send a delegation to authorities concerned to register their



Police personnel stop protesters as they raise slogans during a protest march in Patna on Tuesday.

demand, Patna SSP Kartikeya Sharma told reporters. "Water cannons were used when the situation became tense."

The march was organised on the day the chief minister launched a Vidyarthi Sahayog Shiksha (Student Support Kam) for redressing complaints in educational institutions, and for feedback to improve the facilities. The camps will be organised monthly on the fourth Tuesday in educational institutions. Students can file their complaints and suggestions to officials for redressal of the grievances.

"Every student's voice heard, every problem resolved — this is the resolve, this is the effort," the CM said in a social media post.

Another stir turns violent Meanwhile, hundreds of nursing students who have been protesting against the Bihar Health Sciences University (BHSU) in Patna against alleged irregularities in the examination results clashed with police on Tuesday, leaving several personnel at JP Golamari injured. Four protesters were detained on the charges of ransack and attack on police men.

Protesters alleged that police used baton charge when they arrived university campus with their demands over suspected irregularities in the results.

HC ASKS FOREST DEPT TO EXPEDITE NOD FOR ROAD TO HAMIRPUR SCHOOL

PRAVARGA: The Allahabad High Court has directed the forest department to issue with expedition a no objection certificate (NOC) for construction of a 1.6-km road leading to a school in Uttar Pradesh's Hamirpur, attended by more than 200 children.

A division bench of Chief Justice Arun Bhaskar and Justice Kishiti Shalendra passed the direction on Monday while hearing a suo motu PIL.

The state government informed the court that 0.81 crore had been sanctioned for the road, but construction of the crucial 1.6-km stretch was pending as it falls on forest land. It said efforts to obtain the NOC had been made earlier and a cement road was required due to the terrain.

"We expect the forest department to issue the requisite NOC not at its general pace but with expedition," the court said. The proceedings followed a protest over lack of road access to their school.

The matter will be heard on September 28. **JITENDRA SARIN**

HOUSE PANEL SET TO DISCUSS USE OF FORCE ON NEET PROTESTERS

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Opposition lawmakers on Tuesday held up proceedings in the standing committee of home affairs demanding a discussion on the police excess including the use of pellet guns on students during protests against the alleged irregularities in the NEET-UG 2026 examination at Delhi's Jantar Mantar on July 20, highlighting that the matter should be taken up as it has grabbed the national attention.

Panel chairman, Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) MP Radha Mohan Das Agarwal refused to change the pre-decided topic of the discussion, but agreed to take up a discussion at a later date on "Standard Operating Procedures on use of force on protesters".

Agarwal further pointed out that the matter is sub-judice and the Supreme Court has also formed a probe panel to look into the same issues.

The meeting was attended by Opposition members including Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, Aijaz Maken and Jai Prakash Tripathi of Congress's Derek O'Brien. NCP SP lawyer Manu Supriya Sule, Sanjay Yadav of RJD.

The matter was raised by a Congress member during the meeting where views of officials of various ministries were to be presented on the subject of "crimes against children".

After the rally, the Opposition members relented and the meeting that began at 11 am, went on till 4 pm.

SC seeks Birla's reply on TMC plea

Utkarsh Anand
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday sought a response from Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla to a petition filed by Trinamool Congress (TMC) general secretary and parliamentarian Abhishek Banerjee seeking an expeditious decision on disqualification petitions against 20 TMC MPs who joined the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCP).

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and justices Jyotsna Bagchi and V. Mohana, made it clear that the issue before it was not merely whether notices had been issued to the MPs but whether the disqualification proceedings would be completed.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Speaker, told the bench that there was no need to issue notice to Birla as he was appearing for him and could inform the court that notices had already been issued to the 20 MPs. "It is not a question of issuance of notices but completion of proceedings," the bench said.

It added: "We are not inclined to postpone to a constitutional authority without giving them an opportunity. But we want a response from the Speaker. For now, we will issue notices only to the other respondents."

Senior advocate Kalyan Banerjee, appearing for Banerjee, asked why notice could not also be issued to the Speaker.



TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee's plea invokes the anti-defection law of the Tenth Schedule.

"Mr Bandopadhyay, you want resolution of the matter or an adjudication. We have already said we want a response from the Speaker," the bench said.

The court subsequently ordered issuance of notice to all 20 MPs against whom Banerjee has sought disqualification.

Banerjee has invoked Article 32 of the Constitution to challenge the alleged delay in deciding his petitions seeking disqualification of the 20 rebel MPs. The TMC has maintained that the MPs were elected on its symbol and that their subsequent decision to align with the NCP attracts the anti-defection provisions under the Tenth Schedule.

Banerjee's plea invokes the anti-defection provisions under the Tenth Schedule, contending that the 20 MPs have incurred disqualification by voluntarily giving up their membership of the TMC.

Senior advocate Kalyan Banerjee, appearing for Banerjee, asked why notice could not also be issued to the Speaker.

HC GRANTS ABHISHEK BANERJEE'S PETITION FOR ARREST IN 3 CASES

KOLKATA: The Calcutta High Court on Tuesday directed the police not to take any coercive steps against TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee in three criminal cases against him till November 30, holding that custodial interrogation is not necessary.

Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya directed the Diamond Harbour MP not to travel abroad without the high court's permission. He clarified that the permission granted to Banerjee by the Supreme Court for going abroad for three weeks for medical reasons would not be curtailed by this order. Hearing that custodial interrogation of the TMC leader in connection with the three cases is not necessary, the court directed the police not to take any coercive steps against him till November 30. Justice Bhattacharyya directed the police to file a progress report on the investigation in the three cases when the matter will be taken up for hearing again on November 23.

BJP Leader Rahul Sinha said: "The Supreme Court is clearing it. It is an internal matter of the TMC and I don't want to comment on it. I just want to say that Mamata Banerjee and Abhishek Banerjee have been in the court for a long time and they couldn't retain their MPs." Most of the rebel TMC MPs, who joined the NCP, either couldn't be contacted or refused to take calls.

Kharge, Rahul urge PM to amend caste format in census form

Kiren Rijju and Pawan Kherra
letters@hindustantimes.com

RIJU, KHERRA SPAR OVER 'SWIMMING' ON SOCIAL MEDIA

Himanshi Sharma
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Union parliamentary affairs minister Kiren Rijju on Tuesday slammed Congress leader Pawan Kherra over what he called an "indecent" comment on his swimming, warning that he will report Kherra's "indiscipline conduct" to Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma.

"Dear Pawan Kherra, I'll report to CM Himanta Biswa Sarma if about your indiscipline conduct. If you talk about half-naked swimming. Do you swim with a full suit & coat?" Union minister Rijju wrote on X.

The sharp exchange comes days after Rijju posted a video of himself swimming in a river in Arunachal Pradesh and challenged senior Congress leader Rahul Gandhi to do the same. Kherra had mocked the video as a "half-naked swim," suggesting it showed how deeply Kherra has unsettled the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). He wrote that Rijju "can't even go for a half-naked swim without invoking Rahul Gandhi."

Rijju responded by questioning Kherra's standing to make the remark, pointing to his own record of contesting eight Lok Sabha elections against Kherra's single nomination term in the Rajya Sabha. He said his swim was meant to inspire people around him and had nothing to do with Gandhi.

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Lok Sabha's Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi on Tuesday asked the Prime Minister Narendra Modi to amend the open-ended format the ongoing census is using to collect caste data, something that means that the government could end up with hundreds of thousands of caste names. With no pre-approved list (as was used in completed census under Bhabha and Tagore), this means that census officials have a Herculean task in analysing the data. There are also fears that this could mean the data never sees light of day — much like the 2011 exercise to count castes that failed for the same reason.

But, the argument goes, the caste census, a demand articulated by several parties, including some of the Bharatiya Janata Party's allies could end up being a disaster. Most importantly, it will remain impossible to determine the size of the OBC population in India, as the term "backward" has not even been included in this census.

"In India, a single caste is known by different names, sub-castes, and languages across various regions. Consequently, if members of the same caste are recorded under different names during the census, that single caste would end up fragmented into thousands of different names. This would result in the emergence of hundreds of thousands of caste names, rendering the census data unusable," he said.

In a briefing, Congress' communications chief Jaram Ramesh also accused the government of not doing a proper



Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi

caste enumeration and dubbed the current process as "deception".

Termining the current census unreliable, Kharge and Kherra have not even been included in this census. "If the accurate count of a community is not recorded, any assessment of its status will also be flawed. This will disadvantage backward, extremely backward, and other deprived communities, and will also impact decisions related to education, employment, government schemes, and social justice," he said.

He said that the government should amend the open-ended format the ongoing census is using to collect caste data, something that means that the government could end up with hundreds of thousands of caste names. With no pre-approved list (as was used in completed census under Bhabha and Tagore), this means that census officials have a Herculean task in analysing the data. There are also fears that this could mean the data never sees light of day — much like the 2011 exercise to count castes that failed for the same reason.

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In a briefing, Congress' communications chief Jaram Ramesh also accused the government of not doing a proper

GADKARI'S OFFICE CLARIFIES ON HIS 'GENERATIONAL SHIFT' REMARK

NAGPUR: A remark by Union minister for road transport and highways Nitin Gadkari on a generational shift that triggered speculation about his future plans has no political undertones and has been taken out of context, his office said on Tuesday.

"I have seen many ups and downs in the political arena and fulfilled various responsibilities. But I cannot work as hard as I used to. Work must be handed over to the new generation, while the older generation acts as a guiding hand," the 69-year-old minister said at an event in Nagpur on Sunday, while reflecting on 30 years of active politics.

The comments came amid persistent murmurs of an impending Union Cabinet reshuffle in New Delhi. Gadkari, currently serving his third consecutive term as Union transport minister, has also been facing public and political pushback over the government's ethanol-blended petrol policies.

In an official clarification, his office maintained that his words were taken entirely out of context by sections of the media and had nothing to do with politics. It was speaking specifically about the Laxmanrao Manjar Trust, an organisation established by him that runs schools in tribal areas.

He said that he had no intention of leaving his office. He could no longer take on as much work as before and that the younger generation should be given an opportunity to take over the government. His remarks were clearly related to the functioning and future of the trust.

PRADIP KUMAR
MAITRA



Top court closes plea on CBSE OSM glitches

Abraham Thomas
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday closed a petition challenging glitches in the On-Screen Marking (OSM) evaluation method adopted in the Class XII marking scheme by the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) observing that permitting evaluation at this stage will open a "Pandora's Box".

Dismissing a petition filed by lawyer Rakesh Binjola challenging the glitches that led to discrepancies in results of lakhs of students, a bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said, "Why should we direct the CBSE to open the window for you. This will open a Pandora's Box."

Last week, the Centre and CBSE had agreed to have a permanent mechanism to deal with the OSM glitches seeking a response on whether the earlier window period of one week provided to students seeking revaluation could be reopened.

CBSE, represented by solicitor general Tushar Mehta said it

is in the process of filing a response.

However, Mehta reiterated that the admission process to colleges is over and reopening the window at this belated stage will lead to more problems. He informed the court that when the revaluation window was provided, 168,000 students had applied and claimed relief. He pointed out that the petitioners had missed the bus and cannot now seek any relief.

The bench, also comprising justices Jyotsna Bagchi and V. Mohana told the petitioner, "These are hard cases. But we cannot upset the entire system. It is your bad luck. What can we do?"

The petitioner's lawyer, advocate Lakshminath Shukla, told the court that this is not a relief limited to the petitioner alone but a permanent mechanism to deal with the OSM glitches seeking a response on whether the earlier window period of one week provided to students seeking revaluation could be reopened.

CBSE, represented by solicitor general Tushar Mehta said it

Dead lizard in breakfast: 17 children fall ill due to contaminated food at TN govt school

CHENNAI: At least 17 students at a government-aided school in Poonamallee in Tamil Nadu's Tiruvallur district have fallen ill after a dead lizard was found in their morning breakfast, police said on Tuesday. The students, who already consumed the food provided under the state's breakfast scheme complaint of mild vomiting, they said.

Man steals ₹50L to gift girlfriend iPhone, luxury hotel stays **CHENNAI:** A 25-year-old man from Assam's Jorhat has been arrested for allegedly stealing ₹50 lakh in cash and gold items from his own house to gift his girlfriend expensive gifts. "He has admitted that he gifted his girlfriend ₹15-lakh iPhone, cash and stays at expensive hotels and resorts," an investigating officer said.

Indore water tragedy report submitted to HC **INDORE:** The commission formed to investigate the deaths of several people after drinking contaminated water in Indore's Bhagidwar area eight months ago has submitted its final report to the Madhya Pradesh High Court in a sealed envelope, petitioners in the case said on Tuesday.

CID to probe into 3 alleged poachers' death in Karnataka after post-mortem report **BENGALURU/CHENNAI:** The Karnataka government on Tuesday transferred the investigation into the death of three people, who were killed in an encounter with the Special Forces of the Gauhati Wildlife Sanctioned in the August 14, to CID, a day after their post-mortem reports revealed that they have been shot from a "close range". Forest department alleged that they were poachers. Tamil Nadu LoP Udhayanidhi Stalin sought justice for them.

HC ASKS GOVT TO RELOCATE KIN OF HATHRAS VICTIM

Lucknow: The Allahabad High Court has directed the Uttar Pradesh government to relocate the family of the Hathras gang-rape victim in Ghaziabad or Noida within three months, while expressing strong displeasure over the government's non-compliance of its earlier directions.

A bench of justices Rajan Roy and Justice Singh on Monday further directed that once the rehabilitation is completed, employment should also be provided to one family member, as directed in its July 26, 2022 order. The court also directed the additional chief secretary (home) to file a compliance affidavit and in case of non-compliance, he will have to appear personally before it on November 30.

The bench observed that the high court had earlier directed the state government to consider relocating the victim's family to Ghaziabad or Noida, but the government failed to give due consideration to the request.

Modi reviews six infra projects across 9 states

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday reviewed six infrastructure projects across nine states at the 53rd PRAGATI meeting, directed by Prime Minister Singh on Monday. There are more state projects to be reviewed in the coming days.

Prime Minister Modi said delays in infrastructure projects not only increase costs but also slow down the economic growth for citizens, businesses and the economy.

The projects include the 374.53-km Son Nagar-Andal railway section across Bihar, Jharkhand and West Bengal. The family and West Bengal. The project is designed to be completed by December 2026 and is 30% physically complete. The third and fourth

lines are expected to facilitate faster freight movement while allowing the existing double line to handle passenger traffic more efficiently. Several forest clearances, land acquisition and utility-shifting issues are pending.

The 23.086-crore Luni-Sandari-Bhildi railway doubling project in Rajasthan and Gujarat, which is 30% physically complete, is aimed at improving freight connectivity between Kandla port and northern parts of the country. Land acquisition and transfer issues remain pending in both western states.

In Uttar Pradesh, the PM reviewed the 12,139.62-crore Beusuma-Bijnor section of NH-19. The 35.96-km highway, whose revised cost stands at ₹2,376.90 crore, includes a 2.79-km major bridge over the Ganga and is intended to provide seamless connectivity between Meerut and Pauri. The project is 51% physically complete and is now likely to be completed by December 2026 and is 30% physically complete. The third and fourth

Cabinet nod to 3 extradition treaties

Neeraj Chauhan
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on Tuesday approved signing and ratification of extradition treaties with Kenya, Kazakhstan, and the Kyrgyz Republic, providing a legal framework to combat transnational crimes such as terrorism, drug trafficking and economic crimes and to seek the repatriation of fugitives from these countries.

Apart from clearing new extradition treaties, the cabinet also gave an ex-post facto approval for signing and notifying a similar agreement with Seychelles and Seychelles signed during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit there in June.

"The Union cabinet has approved signing and ratification of extradition treaties with Kenya, Kazakhstan and Republic of Kyrgyz to cooperate in criminal matters. An ex-post facto approval of the signing of the treaty with Seychelles, cleared

requests to foreign countries. Of the 13 countries, 12 are accepted, of which 12 are pending with the foreign governments. Some of the prominent extradition requests are related to fugitives such as businessmen Nirav Modi, Vijay Malia and Mehul Choksi; and Mahadev Online app founders Sourabh Chandra and Ravi Upadhyay.

The MEA said in Parliament that in the last five years, 25 fugitives have been successfully extradited to India. An extradition of a fugitive sought by India can only be done based on a court order and subsequent decision by the government of the requested country.

To be sure, over 274 fugitives have been brought back to India from 36 countries between 2019 and 2026 but through the deportation route — which is a more informal mechanism in which two countries cooperate with each other. The ministry of home affairs (MHA) said in a statement earlier this month that of the 274 fugitives, 139 have been brought back in the last seven years, 17 were wanted in terrorism and narco-terrorism cases, 42 in organised crime, gangsters acts and extrajudicial cases, and 53 booked in sexual offences cases, including under Pocco act.

"Under the vision of a robust and secure India, the Modi government has ensured the return of 274 criminals since 2019, compared with a mere four per year during the UPA regime," home minister Anil Shah said on August 4.

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), the nodal agency for all extradition requests sent to India, has already set up an "extradition cell" to analyse all proposals sent by states, Union territories, and other agencies that "powerful, foolproof" extradition requests "can be sent."

Speaking at the state assembly, energy resources and law minister R Nirmal Kumar said: "DMK's claim that 90% of the land was acquired for developing the Paradur airport project is not true. So far, only the 48% of the land has been acquired which is 48% of the total land has not been acquired."

Responding to Kumar's statement, DMK MP K. Thiruchellu and former minister Thangam Thennarasu said: "Paradur was selected based on the technical feasibility. The DMK aviation ministry is approved Paradur." **HTC**

'DMK DIDN'T GET CLEARANCE FOR 2ND T.N. AIRPORT'

CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu Veterinary Kazhagam (TVK) on Tuesday alleged that the previous Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) government did not receive environmental clearance for the Paradur green-field airport project, a day after chief minister C. Joseph Vanniaswamy announced the government's decision to scrap it.

Speaking at the state assembly, energy resources and law minister R Nirmal Kumar said: "DMK's claim that 90% of the land was acquired for developing the Paradur airport project is not true. So far, only the 48% of the land has been acquired which is 48% of the total land has not been acquired."

Responding to Kumar's statement, DMK MP K. Thiruchellu and former minister Thangam Thennarasu said: "Paradur was selected based on the technical feasibility. The DMK aviation ministry is approved Paradur." **HTC**

Defence industry can now access DRDO missile tech

Press Trust of India

NEW DELHI: Defence minister Rajnath Singh has approved the transfer of DRDO-developed technologies of all conventional missile systems to the Indian private industry for production within the country as part of a larger goal to enhance domestic defence manufacturing.

Under the initiative, the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) will transfer missile technologies to eligible defence firms.

Singh's office said he has "approved the transfer of DRDO-developed technologies of all conventional missile systems to Indian industries for production within the country."

This Transfer of Technology



Rajnath Singh

(ToT) marks an important milestone in promoting greater participation of the Indian industries in the defence ecosystem by enabling them to undertake indigenous production, as per applicable qualifications, certifications and regulatory requirements," it said.

The defence ministry is yet to provide any list of missiles that could be produced by the private

sector under the new initiative.

It is understood that the private sector may be allowed to produce conventional weapons such as Akash air defence missiles, Astra air-to-air missiles and the Agni anti-tank guided missile.

The conventional missiles are those which rely on explosives or kinetic impact to destroy targets. The non-conventional missiles are armed with nuclear, biological, or chemical warheads.

The defence ministry said the "provision will enable successful transition of missile system development to industrial production".

"The objective is to enhance domestic manufacturing capabilities, strengthen the defence industrial base and create oppor-

tunities for the participation of Indian MSMEs and other technology partners in the supply chain," the ministry said.

It added that the initiative aims to enhance operational capability, reduce import dependence and increase domestic value addition, while supporting the growth of India's defence manufacturing sector.

In last few years, the government rolled out a number of measures to boost the domestic defence production. The volume of India's domestic defence production was recorded at ₹1.78 lakh crore in the financial year 2025-26 as against ₹46,000 crore in 2014, according to latest government data. The defence exports have reached ₹38,424 crore in the financial year 2025-26.

INDIAN NAVY SET TO COMMISSION 2ND DIVING VESSEL

NEW DELHI: 'Nipun', the Indian Navy's second Diving Support Vessel (DSV) equipped with modern diving systems and underwater intervention capabilities, is set to be commissioned on August 31, the defence ministry said.

The vessel was delivered to the Indian Navy on July 30 following completion of an extensive programme of outfitting and trials. It is a purpose-built platform designed to support a wide spectrum of diving and underwater operations, the ministry said in a statement on Tuesday.

The Navy is set to commission 'Nipun', the second DSV of the Nistar-class, on August 31 at Naval Dockyard, Mumbai, it said.

"The induction of the specialised vessel will mark an important addition to the Navy's deep-sea diving and underwater support capabilities and herald the beginning of a new chapter in the ship's journey from construction to operational service," the ministry said.

Beacon, life boat of sunken ship found



Indian Coast Guard looking for 22 sailors of Panama-flagged ship MV Ocean Winner that sank off Odisha coast on August 22, found an emergency beacon of the vessel and a lifeboat, officials said on Tuesday. REUTERS

'SURVIVORS UNLIKELY'
ICG spokesperson Commandant Amit Uniyal said: "So far, no debris have been found near the spot where the ship likely sank. But it is highly unlikely of any of the 22 crew members surviving."

PANAMA REQUEST
The directorate general of Maritime Administration has agreed to a request by the Panama Maritime Administration to join the investigation. Rough weather has hampered the rescue operation.

Govt relaxes key sugar import norm amid rising retail prices

Palavi Singh

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The government has relaxed a key condition on duty-free imports of 1 million tonnes of raw sugar, giving refiners up to two months from the date of filing the bill of entry to process the shipment and sell it in the domestic market.

Experts said the move, notified by the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) late on Monday, will boost supplies during the early months of the new sugar season and ease pressure on retail prices.

The earlier deadline was difficult to meet, particularly for shipments that arrive towards the end of October. The relaxation will ensure that the importation process does not get held up because of the refining process and can reach the domestic market in the coming months, a sen-

THE CENTRE ALLOWED THE DUTY-FREE IMPORT OF RAW SUGAR ON AUGUST 20, FIRST SUCH MOVE IN NEARLY A DECADE

ior official at the All India Sugar Trade Association (AISTA) said. Under the original order, importers had to refine and sell the sugar by October 31. While the import arrival deadline remains October 31, refiners now get a rolling two-month window from filing their bill of entry. In simple terms, sugar arriving in late October can now be processed and sold through November and December. This is important because the new sugar season begins in October, and the imported sugar can add to availability during the early

part of the 2026-27 season. "The imports will add to supplies at a time when the new season is just beginning. Along with the early start to crushing, this should help improve availability and prevent the tightness seen this season from carrying forward," the head of an international commodity trading agency said on condition of anonymity. The industry sees closing stocks for 2025-26 sugar season at about 3.2-3.5 million tonnes—the lowest in about two decades. The Centre allowed the duty-free import of raw sugar on August 20, its first such move in nearly a decade, after a sharp rise in retail prices that reached ₹70/kg in key metro cities.

The imported sugar will not enter the market immediately because the government has permitted import of raw sugar, which has to be refined into white sugar before it can be sold to consumers.

DGCA may mandate drug tests on all pilots

Neha LM Tripathi

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The government is currently mulling random drug tests for all pilots, civil aviation minister Ram Mohan Naidu said on Tuesday, articulating a proposal first reported by HT on August 17.

DGCA (Directorate General of Civil Aviation) is having stakeholder consultations right now on what the regulation says today and how we ensure there is a strict policy around this (drug tests for pilots) in the future," Naidu said. The current requirement is for an airline to randomly test 10% of its pilots in a year.

"There are multiple ways of approaching this dope test. So right now, the rule says 10% across the overall pilot network but DGCA is engaging (with airlines) and one of the opinions from our side is that everyone has

to go through it once a year, randomly," the minister said.

The move comes after two Air India pilots failed a preliminary drug test post flight after the airline voluntarily began asking all its pilots to undergo drug tests from August 13. This came after its pilot-in-command on an August 4 Phuket-Delhi flight that lost altitude suddenly, likely due to technical problems, failed both a preliminary and a confirmatory drug test.

"We have to see how all the stakeholders are going to respond to this because one is the safety aspect, and the second thing is the operational impact; we are going to balance both," Naidu said.

The minister also said that apart from Air India, other airlines had also started testing all their pilots.

MP unlikely to sanction minister's prosecution over Colonel remark

Shruti Tomar

letters@hindustantimes.com

BHOPAL: The Madhya Pradesh government is unlikely to grant sanction for prosecuting minister Vijay Shah in the case related to his controversial remarks against Colonel Sofiya Qureshi, two state government officials aware of the matter said on Tuesday.

The decision was taken at a meeting of the state cabinet chaired by chief minister Mohan Yadav. An officer, requesting anonymity, said, "The state government is unlikely to sanction prosecution against Shah as he has already apologised four times in the matter. The government will now submit an affidavit before the Supreme Court on August 31. But the decision is not being made public as the matter is sub-judice."

A second state government official confirmed the decision saying the issue was discussed after most officials were asked to leave the room. Shah's remarks, made during



Vijay Shah

Public works department minister Rakesh Singh said the issue had been on the cabinet's agenda. But "no discussion was held on this issue," he said.

Since the controversy erupted, the MP government has repeatedly delayed action against Shah. The SIT recorded his statement only once and has been awaiting prosecution sanction since January this year. The SIT submitted its report to the state government and informed the Supreme Court that they sought a sanction under Section 196 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, a mandatory step for the court to take cognizance.

Shah's remarks, made during

Operation Sindoor in May 2025, targeted Colonel Qureshi, who had briefed the media alongside Wing Commander Vyomika Singh and Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri. Shah had said, "Those who widowed our daughters, we sent a sister of their own to teach them a lesson. The country's honour and respect and the marital bliss of our sisters can be avenged by sending the sisters of your community to Pakistan."

The Madhya Pradesh High Court ordered an FIR against Shah, while the Supreme Court constituted a SIT to probe the matter. Shah has since insisted he had not intended to insult any woman officer, the Army, or society. "Those words were uttered in the enthusiasm, excitement, and passion of patriotism. The sentiment behind the mistake should be considered," he said.

Kant had earlier observed that repeated apologies were insufficient, saying it was "too late to tender any apology."

Have fun with facts on Sundays

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.



BJP signals solo Pb fight, but some eye SAD tie-up

Smriti Kak Ramachandran
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Senior Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leaders have publicly asserted that the party will fight elections scheduled for early next year in Punjab on its own. However, BJP leaders in the state said that the doors may still be open to erstwhile ally Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD), with at least two senior leaders telling HT that negotiations for an alliance are still going on.

On Monday, the party's national general secretary (organisation) BL Santhosh, who was on a two-day visit to the state, said the BJP will contest all 117 assembly seats in the state, ruling out a revival of the alliance with the SAD. Expectations of an alliance had gained ground after SAD president Sukhbir Singh Badal met Prime Minister Narendra Modi earlier this month.

While addressing state party leaders, Santhosh said Punjab is ready for a change, and the BJP is prepared to make this change a reality. He also expressed confidence that the party would form its first ever government in the state, leaders said.

But a state leader said a segment of party leaders want to join hands with the SAD.

"Moreover the SAD cadre also feels that their party will be better off signing a pre-pol alliance with the BJP...the mood on the

AT LEAST TWO SENIOR LEADERS TOLD HT THAT NEGOTIATIONS FOR AN ALLIANCE WITH ERSTWHILE ALIY SHIROMANI AKALI DAL ARE STILL GOING ON

ground is against the Aam Aadmi Party government and a strong alliance will hugely benefit. SAD leader Birkam Singh Majithia too has made a public statement about the reunion being favoured by the people," said this leader.

Last week, Majithia said SAD leader and lawmaker Harshvir Badal had indicated that people in the state were in favour of the two parties renewing their alliance, which split in 2020 following a disagreement over the now-recalled farm laws.

While the negotiations on possible seat sharing are still a work in progress, the BJP does not want its cadre to depend on an ally, said the leader quoted above. The message to the cadre is to go all out to prepare for the elections on their own steam and not assume that the party will benefit from a vote transfer between allies, should the alliance happen.

"Even in Tamil Nadu, before

the AIADMK came back to the NDA fold, the party's message to the cadre was to prepare to go solo. That is also the way forward to build the party's own network on the ground and strengthen the organisation," said the leader quoted above.

A second leader said the BJP's leadership wants the party cadre not to get swayed by conflicting messages about the alliance being reworked.

"While state president Kewal Singh Dhillon and now BL Santhosh have said there will be no alliance (SAD president Sukhbir Singh) Badal's meeting with Prime Minister Narendra Modi (on August 7) sparked hope that the two oldest allies will reunite. It is therefore, important for the state leadership to focus on strengthening the party at the grassroots level as it does in other states," said the second functionary.

The BJP, which recently appointed newly appointed national general secretary Satish Poonia as the state in-charge, has begun the process of drawing up a possible list of candidates, identifying strongholds and building contact with various social and caste groups.

Largely confined to the urban areas, the party mostly drew support from a section of the non-Jats and Hindus and its vote percentage has been between 6 and 8%.

BSF TO GO IT ALONE IN U'KHAND, UP AND PB ELECTIONS

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

LUCKNOW: Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) chief Mayawati on Tuesday said her party will contest the upcoming assembly elections in Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, and Punjab in the 2027 assembly election to prevent the party from losing its party members' morale due to potential losses in seats and vote percentages from electoral alliances, she said.

Mayawati made the announcement while reviewing the progress of preparations for the assembly elections expected early next year in a meeting with party office-bearers of the three states at her Lucknow residence. She told party leaders from Punjab that the BSP can give hope to the people of the state, who are unhappy and distressed by the anti-people attitudes of the ruling AAP as well as other parties like the Congress and the BJP. The BSP went solo in the 2022 assembly election in UP and Uttarakhand, it went for alliance with the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) in Punjab.

SC DIRECTS TEJPAL TO SURRENDER WITHIN 3 WEEKS

Utarkash Anand
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed former Tehelka editor Tarun Tejpal to surrender within three weeks, rejecting his plea for exemption from surrendering before his appeal against his conviction and 10-year jail term in the 2013 sexual assault case is heard.

Justice Alok Aradhe rejected Tejpal's application seeking exemption from surrender and directed him to furnish a surrender certificate. It ordered that if the certificate is filed on or before September 22, his appeal be listed on that date.

Senior advocate Kailash Sibal and Aman Lekhi, appearing for Tejpal, argued that there was no legal requirement for an accused to surrender before his criminal appeal could be listed. Sibal also relied on the Bombay High Court's August 6 judgement, which had given Tejpal four weeks to surrender while noting that the case was 13 years old and that he was now a senior citizen with strong roots in society.

"There is no legal condition that he must surrender before the appeal is listed," submitted Sibal, adding that there was no legal requirement for a person to surrender before his appeal could be taken up. "There is no point to send him to jail for five days," he said. The bench clarified that Tejpal's exemption plea could not be decided without examining the nature of offence and sentence imposed on him.

H1N1 makes up 98% of influenza cases: CVMR

Rhythmika Kaul
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Swine flu accounts for 98% of influenza cases tested across the country, according to the Indian Council of Medical Research, which also believes that there is no reason for panic as no deaths have been reported from the H1N1 subtype of the influenza A virus so far.

"Our surveillance network has shown about 98% of the cases that are tested are of H1N1; however, there is no need to panic as there is no shift in the seasonal flu pattern that we normally see. There are two peaks usually—monsoon and winters—and the cases that we are seeing are usual for this time of year. We haven't found any trend or pattern out of the usual that should concern us. Having said that we have to be watchful and follow preventive measures," said Dr Rajiv Bahl, director-general, Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR).

Still, in a country where it is estimated that less than 2% of the population has ever received a flu shot, leave alone an annual one, the flu can spread rapidly given the absence of any kind of herd immunity against a virus with a moderate reproduction number (1.3-2.8 according to previous estimates, though this sometimes varies by outbreaks), which is a measure of how contagious it is. Annual flu shots are the only insurance

ICMR SAID THERE IS NO REASON FOR PANIC AS NO DEATHS HAVE BEEN REPORTED FROM THE H1N1 SUBTYPE OF THE INFLUENZA A VIRUS SO FAR

against seasonal flu outbreaks. To be sure, flu shots are cost-prohibitive, ranging from ₹2,000 to ₹4,000, so not everyone can afford it, especially in a country like India.

Bahl added that while the number of infections may have risen over the past few weeks, there aren't too many severe cases needing hospitalisation. "Some cases are severe, but the number is not unusually high. And those who require admissions are usually people who have some underlying medical condition. But the trend also suggests that the worst (in terms of infections) is yet to come."

"We can never know when the peak is going to hit until the number of cases start plateauing and then coming down. So far, the trend shows the number of infections is going up," he said.

ICMR is tracking cases closely. "There is a robust surveillance network in place. All 22 hospitals across the country that function as sentinel sites for syndromic and other testing. There are 73 labs

that test at least 25 samples each in a week to accurately identify infection (SAR) and influenza-like illness (ILI) to know which pathogens are circulating in the community," Bahl added. Hospitals say there has been an uptick in the number of admissions related to respiratory illnesses but that the numbers are not overwhelming, and people are getting better. Dr Sumit Ray, medical superintendent, Holy Family Hospital, Delhi.

ICMR said on Sunday that the strain was a new, and available vaccines were effective against the current strain. "The Influenza A (H1N1) pdm09 viruses currently circulating in the country are closely related to the A/Missouri/1/2025 (H1N1) pdm09-like virus strain. These viruses belong to clade 6B.1A.5a2a, subclade D.3.1.1 and have been in circulation since 2025," said ICMR.

"The Influenza strains currently circulating are also well matched with the vaccine strains recommended by the World Health Organisation for the Northern Hemisphere."

Based on these recommendations, companies issue annual vaccines. According to US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, almost half the adult population in the US takes a flu shot.

Ram Rahim gets another furlough; Akal Takt slams move

Neeraj Mohan
letters@hindustantimes.com

ROHTAK: Dera Sacha Sauda chief Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh, 58, who has been serving a 20-year prison term for raping two women disciples, walked out of Haryana's high-security Sunaria jail in Rohtak early on Tuesday after being granted a 2-day furlough, marking his 17th temporary release from prison since October 2020 and the third such release this year.

The release prompted sharp reaction from the Akal Takht, with acting jathedar Giani Kuldeep Singh Gargaj questioning the alleged "double standards"

adopted by the governments.

"Why is Ram Rahim being granted repeated paroles while Sikh prisoners are facing a different yardstick? By this standard, parole should be granted to Sikh prisoners too. Jagtar Singh Hawara should be granted parole to meet his elderly mother, while the issue of Balwant Singh Rajwaha is also stuck. Devinderpal Singh Bhullar could have been released by now, but the then-Delhi government did not sign the file," the jathedar said.

Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandh Committee (SGPC) president Harjinder Singh Dhillon said the move reflected a "double and



Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh

discriminatory" approach. "Governments had repeatedly extended furlough and parole to the Dera head, while Sikh prisoners have remained incarcerated for decades and been denied even parole. Governments must understand that such double standards further deepen the sense of alienation among the

Sikh community," Dhillon said.

Former jathedar and SAD (Punjab) head Giani Harpreet Singh termed it an act that "rubs salt into the wounds" of the Sikh community.

"Despite leaders of the Qaumi Insaaf Morcha offering to take responsibility for Hawara's parole, he has not been released, while a convict in a rape case is repeatedly being released," Giani Harpreet said in a statement.

Leaders of Akali Dal (Waris Punjab) Deo also demanded the release of Sikh prisoners who have completed their sentences and sought parole for Hawara. Cabinet minister Krishan Lal Panwar said the matter falls

under the jurisdiction of the high court. "Decisions regarding parole are taken in accordance with court directions and the prescribed rules and procedures," said the minister.

A special CBI court had in 2017 convicted the controversial religious preacher for raping two women disciples.

With the latest release, Ram Rahim will have spent 457 days outside prison on parole or furlough since his 2017 conviction. The furlough comes less than a month after he returned to Sunaria jail on June 26 following a 30-day parole granted in May. He was also granted 40 days of parole in January.

CBI filed a record 1,005 cases and preliminary enquires in '25: Report

Neeraj Chauhan
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) registered 1,005 cases and preliminary enquiries (PEs) in 2025, the highest ever in a single year and nearly 48% more than 2020 when it filed 676 cases and enquiries, according to the latest annual report of the Central Vigilance Commission (CVC) and agency data independently reviewed by HT.

"During the year 2025, 1,005 regular cases, PEs and Lokpal referrals were registered by CBI. Out of the 1,005 cases, 161 cases were taken up on the orders of the constitutional courts and 27 cases on the references received from the state governments and union territories," stated the CVC's 2025 annual report, seen by HT.

The agency had registered a total of 840 cases in 2024, 876 in 2023, 946 in 2022, 747 in 2021 and 676 in 2020, according to previous years' CVC reports.

CBI officials, who questioned anonymity, attributed the increase in numbers to a proactive approach by the federal agency, particularly in its core duties—trapping corrupt government servants while taking bribes and registering disproportionate assets (DA) cases.

"Other than special crimes,

CBI OFFICIALS ATTRIBUTED THE INCREASE IN NUMBERS TO A PROACTIVE APPROACH BY THE FEDERAL AGENCY

bank frauds, and other economic offences, a special focus for the past couple of years has been to target the corrupt officers, which is our core work. Subsequently, multiple cases have been registered to investigate digital arrest sessions, human trafficking, shop works in south-east Asia and builders-bankers' nexus to attract homebuyers," said an officer, who asked not to be named.

In 2025, the CVC report said, CBI laid 265 traps against government servants for detection of bribery cases. It also registered 81 cases to investigate possession of disproportionate assets by government servants.

Officials said that the trap and DA cases averaged around 100-150 till the last couple of years. It is also for the first time ever that CBI has registered 81 DA cases in a year.

Another area where CBI has performed well, according to CVC, is completing investigations in its cases. In 2025, the report says, CBI completed probes in 1064 cases.

M.P. BRIDGE LANDS ON FARM AFTER ALIGNMENT TWEAK

Shruti Tomar
shruti.tomar@hindustantimes.com

BHOPAL: An under-construction bridge in Madhya Pradesh, connecting Indore and Ujjain, has landed on a private farmland after its alignment was altered by 30 degrees, leaving the Ujjain Municipal Corporation (UMC) with the challenge of acquiring 4,000-5,000 sq ft of land to link the bridge to the main road, directly into private farmland.

PWD bridge section executive engineer PS Pant defended his department. He said, "The bridge is constructed as per the plan and said the approach road was UMC's responsibility."

UMC superintendent engineer RK Jain said that his department is part of engineering reinforcements. The bridge is yet to be completed. Ideally, a bridge should be at 90 degrees to the river flow to reduce flood pressure and obstruction. The earlier skew design increased flood load and debris risk, so it was changed. Now, a small portion of private land is required for the approach road. This is not a mistake but a necessary change," Jain said.

Have fun with facts on Sundays

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.

Image showing a preview of the 'Have fun with facts on Sundays' column from the Sunday Hindustan Times, featuring a quiz on the week's development.

AIMPLB to move HC on dismissal of student's plea seeking nod for hijab

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

LUCKNOW: The All India Muslim Personal Law Board (AIMPLB) said on Tuesday that it is likely to approach the Allahabad high court challenging its dismissal of a petition seeking permission for a student to wear a hijab or headscarf with the school uniform.

"The high court's decision regarding hijab needs a review. There is no uniform confusion. As far as Islam is concerned, hijab or pardah is an integral part of Islam, proven through the Holy Quran and Hadees," Maulana Khawaz Ahmad, as-prang Mahali, chairman of the

Islamic Centre of India and a member of the executive committee of AIMPLB, said. "AIMPLB would seek a review and its legal experts would present the case with facts and references. It seems the lawyers had been unable to present the case effectively before the court," he added.

In August 21 judgment, a two-judge bench of Justices JJ Munir and Indrajit Shukla had dismissed a petition of a Class II student of a private school, who was seeking permission to wear headscarf with the school uniform.

The bench had observed that the petitioners failed to prove religious scriptures or other mate-

rial before the court to establish that wearing a hijab was an essential religious practice. It had said that "wearing a headscarf is not essential part of the Islamic faith for a woman to do, in the absence of which, faith would be jeopardised."

The judges also noted that other girls from the same religious community were not wearing scarves.

Maulana Yasooq Abbas, general secretary and spokesperson for the All India Muslim Personal Law Board (AIMPLB), termed the court's observation "very sad."

"Hijab is absolutely compulsory in Islam. It is wrong to stop a girl from wearing a hijab while attending school," he said.

5 of AP family found dead; suicide suspected

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu
letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: Five members of a family were found dead in a lodge room in the temple town of Srisailem in Andhra Pradesh's Nandyal district on Tuesday, with police suspecting the incident a suicide pact linked to financial difficulties.

The deceased was identified as a 36-year-old man, his three sisters, aged 33, 45 and 50, and his 15-year-old nephew, all residents of Sri Satya Sai Ashram, Atmakur deputy superintendent of police (DSP) Ramani Naik told reporters that the family members were found dead in a room of Vaddera Satram, a village run by the Vaddera community in Srisailem.

However, the family reportedly told the management that they were unwell and continued to stay," he said.

The lodge's staff told police that they had not seen any of the family members for the past three days.

"On Tuesday, the lodge staff noticed a strong foul smell from the room and went to check on the occupants. After finding the bodies, they alerted the Srisailem town police," Naik said.

Police rushed to the spot, inspected the room, registered a case of suspicious death and launched an investigation, the

DSP said.

Police inquiry revealed that the 36-year-old man was unmarried, while two of his sisters were living at their parental home after separating from their husbands.

"We have learnt that the family had been facing financial difficulties. We suspect these problems may have led to the deaths," Naik said.

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India not a dharamshala, only citizens of the country have right to live here: Shah

Neeraj Chauhan

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Union home minister Amit Shah on Tuesday reiterated that India was "not a dharamshala", saying only citizens had the right to live in the country and that infiltrators posed a threat to India's security, economy and demographics.

"This country is not a dharamshala (charitable rest house); only citizens of the country have the right to live here," Shah said, speaking at the valedictory session of the National Security Strategy conference of the Intelligence Bureau (IB), attended by chiefs of central agencies and state police forces.

Stressing that infiltrators threatened the country's "security, economy and demographics", the home minister said, "Over the past eight months, after visiting all states sharing land borders, we have shared a document outlining a four-pronged approach to border security with the states. Our goal is to make the country free of



Amit Shah

infiltrators in a very short period."

Shah said India's security policy had to be framed against the backdrop of global instability, insecurity around energy and resources, supply-chain disruptions, rising radicalisation and the warfare of cyber misinformation. A strong internal security apparatus, he said, was a prerequisite for a developed India. "If India is to emerge at the forefront in every field, its internal security will have to be further strengthened."

Over the two-day NSS conference, intelligence agencies and security forces discussed infiltration, real-time intelligence-sharing

against terror groups, and the dismantling of their logistics and funding networks, among other national security matters.

Shah made similar remarks in Lok Sabha on March 27 while replying to the debate on the Immigration and Foreigners Bill, 2025. On that occasion, he had said India was "not a dharamshala where anyone can come and stay for any purpose", arguing that Parliament had the right to bar those who posed a threat to national security, and that sensitive locations and army establishments along the borders could not be left open to all. Those who came legally to contribute to India's prosperity were welcome, he said, but illegal entrants would be dealt with strictly.

The Supreme Court too used phrasing when on May 19, a bench of justices Dipankar Datta and K Vinod Chandan declined to intervene in the detention of a Sri Lankan Tamil national facing deportation after a seven-year sentence under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act. "Is India to

host refugees from all over the world? We are struggling with 140 crore. This is not a dharamshala that we can entertain foreign nationals from all over."

Attacking previous governments, Shah on Tuesday said had they anticipated the problems of narcotics, Naxalism and insurgency in the northeast before they became enormous challenges, "the country would not have had to suffer their consequences for decades." He said the challenges in the country's three internal security hotspots had been eliminated, and credited state police forces, central agencies and the central armed police forces (CAPFs).

Asking officers to look for trends over the next 15 to 20 years, Shah said they should identify problems that might arise and work out strategies to prevent them. He also directed state police forces to implement the Narcotics Control Vision document 2020-2029 on the ground and work on the "three Ds — Detect, Disrupt and Destroy" — to achieve a drug-free India.

{ K'TAKA GOVT CRACKDOWN ON SALE OF DHATURA }

E-retailers in dock for selling toxic fruit

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: The Karnataka government has directed authorities to suspend, until further orders, the food licences of e-commerce platforms Amazon, Swiggy Instamart and Bigbasket over the online sale and distribution of Dhatura fruits/seeds, citing public health and food safety concerns.

The government also ordered the immediate suspension of the licences/registrations of establishments and sellers supplying products to the three online platforms. It directed all concerned food business operators to remove listings, advertisements, and promotional material relating to Dhatura ('thorn apple' in English) intended for food or human consumption.

"In accordance with the provisions of the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006 and the Rules/Regulations made there-

THE GOVERNMENT ALSO ORDERED SUSPENSION OF THE LICENCES OF SUPPLIERS OF PRODUCTS TO THE THREE ONLINE PLATFORMS

under, the concerned competent authorities have been directed to take necessary action for the suspension, until further orders, of the food licences issued to the e-commerce platforms, namely Amazon, Swiggy Instamart and Bigbasket, and to submit a compliance report forthwith," the Food Safety and Drug Administration said in a press release.

The department said the issue came to its notice after Dhatura fruits/seeds were found displayed for sale on certain online platforms under FSSAI licences/

registrations.

Online commerce firms require a central FSSAI licence, with third-party sellers too expected to submit FSSAI licences.

"The Dhatura plant possesses toxic properties, and the consumption of its fruits and seeds may cause serious adverse effects on human health," it said.

The department added that their sale, distribution, display for sale or promotion for food use or human consumption through online platforms was a matter of serious concern from the point of view of public health and food safety.

The department directed food business operators to immediately discontinue all online listings, advertisements and promotional activities relating to Dhatura fruits/seeds and strictly prohibited their sale or distribution for food or human consumption in future.

It said the suspension of the licences of Amazon, Swiggy Instamart and Bigbasket would remain in force until further orders.

Upon receipt of compliance reports, the issue of revocation of the suspension would be considered separately after providing the concerned parties an opportunity of hearing.

"The concerned State/Central Designated Officers and Food Safety Officers have also been directed to take immediate action for the suspension of the licences/registrations of the establishments and sellers supplying the above-mentioned products to the said online entities, with immediate effect," the department said.

The government directed all the food business operators and online platforms concerned to ensure "strict and immediate compliance" with the directions in the interest of public health and food safety.

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SC-PROTEST PROBE

Mehta, appearing for the Delhi Police, opposed the application, describing it as "mischievous" and objecting to the petitioners' demand for reconstitution of the committee. When Sankaranarayanan said the petitioners were only seeking listing of the application, Mehta pointed out that it also named judges whom the petitioners wanted on the panel, apart from seeking probe against certain ministers.

"We don't appreciate mentioning names of the judges like this," the CJ told Sankaranarayanan.

At this point, advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for another petitioner, said there were "some misgivings" among petitioners but stressed that they were pursuing a common cause.

Mehta, however, said some petitioners had "misgivings about everyone and all institutions" and described the application as "certainly not in good taste".

The application, filed a day ago by petitioner Shailesh Mani Tripathi, seeks reconstitution of the HPEC, contending that it does not have the composition and expertise necessary to conduct an independent probe into the allegations. The petitioner has sought that the committee be headed by a retired Chief Justice of India and include independent members with relevant expertise.

The petitioners had earlier proposed that a former CJ head the panel and had suggested the names of Justices Uday U Lalit, Sanjay Khanna and Bhushan R Gavi for consideration. They had also proposed the inclusion of a retired woman DGP and a former Attorney General, besides investigative officers and forensic and technical experts.

The application questions the absence of these categories of members from the committee constituted by the Supreme Court on August 18. It alleges that publicly available information about the non-judicial members does not show specialised experience in investigating excessive use of police force or examining senior executive and police officials. It also raises a "structural concern" about the committee's independence, while clarifying that the objection is not directed at the personal integrity of any member.

The petitioners have specifically sought an inquiry into the alleged role of Union home minister Amit Shah, Delhi Police commissioner Anurag Kumar and other senior officials of the Ministry of Home Affairs, Delhi Police and the Rapid Action Force. The application says such an inquiry would examine, among other things, directions issued before and during the July 20 protest, instructions concerning the use of force, and disciplinary action against personnel accused of excessive or unlawful force.

The proposed terms of reference also seek an investigation into the chain of command and accountability for alleged excessive use of force, including allegations involving weapons and equipment such as pellet guns and electric batons, as well as alleged planting of evidence at protest sites.

The July 20 march to Parliament by protesting students came weeks after the agitation against leaks in the NEET test paper that necessitated a retest began; the protests, catalysed and headed by the Cockerroach Janta Party, also demanded the resignation of then education minister Dharmendra Pradhan. The government eventually gave in to the demands on July 25 and the same day, Pradhan resigned. The government also set up a committee headed by Infosys chairman Nandan Nilekani to reform the test process and launched efforts to strengthen the test conducting agency NTA.

The Supreme Court had on July 28 recorded that the allegations prima facie warranted an independent and impartial investigation into the incidents of violence. The Union government and Delhi government had stated that they had no objection to an independent and fair probe, while denying that the police had committed excesses.

The HPEC, headed by Justice (retired) Reddy, was constituted by the Supreme Court to conduct an independent and impartial inquiry into competing allegations arising from the July 20 student protest - petitions alleging excessive force by police as well as pleas concerning violence against police personnel and legality of the protest.

Other members of the committee include Justice (retired) Ravi Shankar Jha, former chief justice of the Punjab and Haryana high court; justice (retired)

Shalinder Kaur, former Delhi high court judge; Rishi Kumar Shukla, former Central Bureau of Investigation director; and LR Bishnoi, retired director general of police, Meghalaya.

Its mandate extends beyond the immediate allegations of police violence. The committee has been asked to examine the use of pellet guns, electric batons, lathi and tear gas, the proportionality of police action, the use of blanket prohibitory orders, surveillance of protesters and the invocation of Section 152 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, which criminalises acts endangering the sovereignty, unity and integrity of India.

The committee has also been asked to examine allegations of violence by protesters against police personnel, damages to public property and injuries suffered by security personnel.

On the allegations concerning women protesters, the court had specifically directed the panel to examine incidents of targeted violence, harassment, molestation and secondary victimisation, besides assessing medical and other support provided to victims and the possibility of interim compensation.

The court had also directed the authorities to preserve CCTV and drone footage, body-worn camera recordings, videography, wireless communication records and PCR call logs relating to the protests and hand them over to the committee.

The committee can receive documentary evidence and representations from affected persons and has been permitted to allow anonymous complaints to protect the identities of complainants and witnesses.

The HPEC is required to submit interim findings periodically, with its first report to cover allegations of grievous injuries caused by police and security personnel and the complaints concerning targeted violence, harassment and molestation of women protesters.

SC-WEST BENGAL S.I.R.

SIR appellate tribunals comprise former chief justices and judges of high courts and were constituted to hear challenges to decisions taken by judicial officers who adjudicated claims and objections in the revision process.

The RTI response showed that as on August 7, a total of 3,810,620 appeals had been sub-

mitted before the appellate tribunals across West Bengal. Of these, 75,443 appeals had resulted in the inclusion of names in the electoral rolls, while 7,339 had resulted in exclusion. This means that of the 82,782 appeals whose outcomes had been recorded, more than 91% resulted in the inclusion of names in the electoral rolls.

Senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan, appearing for a petitioner seeking expeditious disposal of appeals against exclusion, placed the RTI response before the bench and said the figures showed that the tribunals were being burdened by a large number of appeals seeking deletion of voters.

The lion's share of appeals seeking disenfranchisement can't burden this Tribunal in priority. Let the Tribunals prioritise those who were excluded," Sankaranarayanan submitted. He said the disposal data showed that a large majority of the appeals decided so far had resulted in restoration or inclusion of names in the electoral rolls. The bench took note of the unusual distribution of appeals, as it observed that a "very large chunk" of the appeals were for inclusion-related objections.

Sankaranarayanan suggested that the tribunals should first take up the appeals filed by persons who had been excluded from the rolls, leaving challenges to inclusions to be dealt with through remedies available under the Representation of the People Act.

Advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for petitioner Shreshjit Bose, supported the plea for expeditious disposal of appeals, citing a fixed schedule for their disposal. The application, filed through advocate Neha Rath, also demanded a time-bound schedule for disposal of all appeals against exclusion in the wake of upcoming municipal polls in the eastern state.

The court said it had already sought data on the functioning and disposal of appeals in another matter and could consider whether additional tribunals were required after examining the figures. It added that the distinction between the two categories of appeals was significant because exclusion from the electoral roll immediately affects a statutory right, while an objection to someone's inclusion might not carry the same

urgency.

The bench accordingly directed the Election Commission of India to file an affidavit giving a district-wise and category-wise picture of the appeals. It sought details of the total number of pending appeals, the break-up between appeals filed by excluded persons and those challenging inclusions, the number disposed of, the nature of relief sought, the number allowed and the consequential steps taken to update the electoral rolls.

The court also asked ECI to explain why it was taking to streamline and expedite disposal of the pending appeals.

Senior advocate Dama Seshadri Naidu, appearing for ECI, said the poll body had recently met members of the tribunals and would furnish the information sought by the court. He also asked to obtain instructions on the RTI response. The court's concern over the time available for disposal was underlined towards the end of the hearing when the CJ said the entire exercise should be completed before the next parliamentary election. "Before the Parliament election comes, everything must be sorted out," it remarked. The issue of prioritising exclusion appeals arose from petitions seeking a time-bound mechanism for disposal of challenges by voters whose names were deleted during the SIR exercise.

During the hearing, senior advocate Kalyan Bandhopadhyay, appearing for a Trinamool Congress member, also referred to data from 31 assembly constituencies where the number of deletions was higher than the winning margin of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) over the TMC candidate in the last assembly elections. The bench, however, made clear that it would not confine its examination to those constituencies and would instead consider the disposal of appeals across the state. It observed that the relevance of the deletions to the election results would depend, among other things, on how many of those whose names were deleted had actually changed their exclusion.

BOY DROWNS IN DRAIN

The basic safety and security compromises poor people like us face every day," said 34-year-old Devi, who works as a domestic help in the neighbourhood.

Mithun, who was in Class 8 in a

private school, is survived by his parents and three siblings, aged eight, 12 and 17.

"The boy could not be traced because the water was flowing rapidly in the drain," said deputy commissioner of police (south-east) Vineet Kumar.

He said the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) joined the operation around 4pm on Saturday and added that operations continued throughout, except at night.

A video clip of Kumar, who cleans sewers for a living, sitting by the drain and ploughing through the garbage with his hands went viral on social media. The reception to that video, said Kumar, forced the Delhi government and civic authorities to take the search seriously.

Kumar said he was ready to jump into the drain.

"I don't know how to swim, but I was still ready to go into the drain and rescue him. Eight to 10 people, including my relatives and neighbours, were also ready. But the police did not allow it, saying it was risky. They even used force to disperse us when we insisted. My son may have been found earlier, had the rescue teams made serious efforts," said Kumar.

The family and some local residents even protested against the alleged inaction on Sunday.

A senior police officer, who asked not to be named, said the police and other authorities were present at the rescue site since they were informed about the incident and made their best efforts to retrieve the boy's body.

"The search and rescue operation was full of challenges. The flow of water made it impossible to remain at one point and find the body. The drain is full of sludge, garbage and pipes that hampered the search. Also, there was no direct way for earthmovers to reach the drain. The machines first created a path for themselves and then went closer to the drain to remove the garbage and finally find the body," added the officer.

Mithun's death is the latest in a string of similar civic tragedies that have beset Delhi this year, exposing the brittle infrastructure across the city and underlying the complete lack of administrative preparedness.

On Monday, a junior engineer of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) was suspended after chief minister Rekha Gupta expressed "strong displeasure and

deep sorrow" over the incident. Gupta on Tuesday announced ₹5 lakh as financial aid for his family.

Mithun wanted to become a computer science engineer, said his parents. The 5'5" tall boy was also adept at sketching and painting, they added.

"To fulfil his dreams, we enrolled him at a computer coaching centre. He was a responsible and caring child. The night before he drowned, he brought two packets of chips and persuaded me to eat one of them," said his mother.

For the family, from Badaun in Uttar Pradesh, the ordeal started around 11am on Saturday. Mithun fell into the drain that flows metres away from their rented single-room accommodation in a packed lane in Jaspota village.

His parents were out for work and the three siblings were inside the house.

The family's home in Jaspota village is lined by two drain sluices that flow towards Shaheen Bagh Metro station. The neighbourhood itself is sandwiched between the Okhla sewage treatment plant on the west and the Shaheen Bagh drain on the east. The rickety houses, mostly one or two stories high, are situated in a narrow, little space between them. In the narrow lanes these houses are built on, layers of trash and waste hide the streets from view. The inescapable smell of sewage reeks the air.

A five-year-old boy saw Mithun fall into the drain and alerted the neighbours, who then called Mithun's parents. They rushed to the drain within 15 minutes and informed the police. Then, some officers from the Sarita Vihar police station and two fire tenders arrived and began the search and rescue - a torturous process that stretched over three days that would test the family's resolve and eventually break it.

In that time, Devi and Kumar ate little. "How could we think about food and water when our son's life was at stake? I had one samosa in the morning today (Tuesday), and a bowl of rice and dal on Monday. On Sunday also, all my family members survived on samosas that our relatives and neighbours forced us to eat," said Kumar. The latest loss is likely to take place on Wednesday, after the autopsy is completed at the trauma centre of the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS).

Locals said the drain is choked with garbage, complicating the search.

On Monday, the civic agencies removed garbage from multiple points between the spot where the boy fell and the place where his body was eventually recovered. "The authorities wake up only when any tragedy falls and someone loses their life. There are two drains in our neighbourhood but both are open and do not have even boundary walls. People have drowned in the drain earlier," said Mohammad Riyaz, a resident. While the National Green Tribunal (NGT) has reiterated that drains are not covered to allow for regular cleaning, desludging and release of toxic gases, there are no specific rules regarding proper barricading or installing grills to prevent people from falling in.

The drain was initially believed to be under the Delhi Jal Board (DJB), but agency officials said that it had been handed over to MCD for maintenance.

MCD officials did not respond to requests for comment.

But the official back-and-forth will do little for Devi, Kumar or their children.

"The government can compensate by at least securing the open drains so that no other families face tragedies like us," said Devi.

Mithun is among a number of children who have died in Delhi this year after falling into open drains or uncovered pits. On July 9, a seven-year-old boy died after he allegedly fell into a waterlogged vacant plot while defecating in the open at Sanjay Colony in northwest Delhi's Samaypur Badli. On May 3, a two-year-old girl died after falling into an open drain in north Delhi's Mukundpur area.

DOVAL IN CHINA
Stability, and ensuring peace and tranquillity in border areas.

According to a readout from the external affairs ministry, the Indian side "highlighted the

importance of maintaining peace and tranquillity in the India-China border areas for the continued development and progress of the bilateral relationship". The readout added that the special representatives had a "candid and in-depth" exchange on the boundary question and agreed to seek a political settlement in the "context of their overall and long-term interests".

The two sides noted progress in implementing the consensus reached between Modi and Xi in Kazan in October 2019 and Tianjin in August 2025. They expressed satisfaction at the resumption of people-to-people and cross-border exchanges, including the Kalash Manasarovar Yatra and border trade through three designated trading points.

A statement from China's foreign ministry said both sides held "in-depth discussions on advancing border demarcation negotiations, strengthening border control, improving mechanisms, and promoting cross-border cooperation". They reaffirmed their commitment to the political guiding principles finalised in 2005 and agreed to leverage the special representatives mechanism to seek a "fair, reasonable and mutually acceptable comprehensive solution" to the border issue.

Neither side provided details on progress, if any, on negotiations focusing on boundary delineation and demarcation.

This was the third meeting of the special representatives since India and China reached an understanding in October 2024 to end a standoff in the Ladakh sector of the Line of Actual Control (LAC) that dragged on for more than four years and took tens of thousands of lives since the 1962 border war. That understanding was followed by a meeting between Modi and Xi in Kazan, Russia, where they unveiled measures to normalise ties.

In his opening remarks, Doval described the talks as "very important", as they were being held ahead of the Brics summit. "I am happy [that] over the past year, our relationship has been steadily returning to normalcy. The normalcy we have witnessed in our relationship has been a direct result of both sides maintaining peace and tranquillity in the border areas," Doval said.

Xi is expected to make his first visit to India in seven years to attend the Brics summit in September. The talks also came weeks after reports of a face-off between Indian and Chinese troops along the LAC in Arunachal Pradesh.

While the Indian side insisted that the state of the border will determine the overall course of bilateral ties, Wang reiterated China's position of putting the border issue in its "proper place" in the relationship.

Wang noted that institutionalised exchanges and cooperation are gradual processes and both sides are "jointly committed to maintaining peace and tranquillity in the border areas", China's statement said.

"Both sides should learn from historical experience, place the border issue in its proper place within bilateral relations, and move forward without stagnation, regression, or deviation," Wang said.

Wang added that the stable development of China-India ties meets the aspirations of the Global South as relations have "transcended the bilateral scope and possess global and strategic significance".

China is willing to work with India to eliminate differences and overcome obstacles to achieve "a harmonious coexistence between the dragon and the elephant", he said.

Besides discussing regional and international issues, the two sides agreed to hold the 26th meeting of the special representatives in India in 2027.

Doval also met Chinese vice president Han Zheng to discuss ways to strengthen peace and tranquillity in border areas and improve bilateral relations across economic, political, and multilateral spheres.

1 dead in J&K bridge collapse



An under-construction flyover along the Delhi-Amritsar-Katra Expressway collapsed in Jammu and Kashmir's Samba district on Tuesday and killed one labourer and left three others injured, officials said.

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.



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Sunday Hindustan Times

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Take a cue from the clues

Authors who are not authors indeed who no longer read a happy open world but just walls, and each support in a literal village. Have happened this work. Take the quiz to find out

NEW CLUES START JANUARY 21, 2024

Natasha Kapur

Answer: Books! In an article on Question 8, the "world" refers to the world of literature, not the physical world. The clue is a play on words, referring to the fact that authors who are not authors (i.e., who have stopped writing) are often found in libraries or bookstores, which are often referred to as "book worlds" or "literary villages".

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OPINION

The
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{ OUR TAKE }

Freed by tighter H-1B squeeze

New curbs should prompt India to work on an alternative vision to harness homegrown talent

To H-1B, or not to H-1B was never really a choice for Indian IT services companies through the 1990s and the 2000s; nor was it so for American companies hiring Indians, directly or through staffing services companies, in the two decades. That second number is much larger than the first. In the 2000s, for instance, roughly 600,000 Indians were issued H-1B visas, with only around 100,000 of these working for Indian IT firms. Clearly, American industry leveraged the visas to its benefit a lot more than Indian software companies.

For many Indians looking to build careers and lives in the US, H-1Bs were the golden ticket. Their children, born in the US, automatically became citizens—this is one of the provisions of birthright citizenship that the Trump administration sought to change in January, a move that has since been blocked by the courts. They themselves could become citizens by joining the green card queue (although, given the backlog, most of those who went to the US from India on H-1B visas in the 1990s and 2000s are still likely to be in queue).

The Donald Trump administration has targeted H-1B visas for some time, because it sees these as part of the problem (as defined by the MAGA wave) with immigration into the US. While the earlier, prohibitive visa fees of \$100,000 for H-1B applicants has been blocked by the courts, the new \$103,265 fee, similarly questioned by experts, comes with a vengeance. Touted as a filing fee for every cap-subject H-1B visa application at the time of submission, it doesn't exempt Indians already living in the US for education.

Trump's supporters are divided on the H-1B squeeze: Elon Musk and Vivek Ramaswamy favour liberalising the visa regime to benefit American industry, while many prominent MAGA Republicans want it tightened further in the name of protecting American workers. Trump's visa policy not only narrows entry for workers from abroad but has also impacted admissions at US universities. For a country built by immigrants, it's not an insignificant turn of events. And, as for India, the visa squeeze should prompt a search for an alternative vision for harnessing the country's homegrown talent.

Vijay's rocky policy runway in Tamil Nadu

One aspect of governance that has served Tamil Nadu rather well is the relative coordination between the two Dravidian majors—the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam and All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam—when it comes to major industrial and policy developments. Barring some exceptions—such as when former chief minister (CM) J Jayalalitha scrapped her rival M Karunanidhi's ₹1,200 crore demand assembly-concretariat project, and turned it into a government hospital—on the two parties have largely converged on the state's industrial and social justice needs, ensuring continuity of governance for ordinary people and relative shielding of political risk for investors. The state's powerful bureaucracy has historically played a key role in building this relative harmony, against the backdrop of political upheaval in other states where infrastructure, development and social initiatives are often at the mercy of the party in power.

Now, that appears to be changing. This week, Tamil Nadu CM C Joseph Vijay announced the scrapping of a second airport for Chennai at Parandur, four years after his predecessor, M K Stalin, announced the project about 60km west of Tamil Nadu's capital. The reason he gave was the displacement of several farmers in 12 villages, who were also protesting against land acquisition.

The decision might serve the political interests of the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), which had promised the scrapping of the project, but it could end up hurting the investment potential of the Tamil Nadu capital that is not only competing with Bengaluru and Hyderabad, but also struggling with problems at its current airport, rated far below its southern rivals. TVK's promise of acquiring minimal agricultural land also sounds good on paper but as other states have found out, implementing such pledges is far trickier. With his surprise victory earlier this year, Vijay had upset every known political equation in Tamil Nadu. Now in power, it remains to be seen if his government upends the development models of earlier administrations and forges a new path—while continuing to deliver on the state's record of high growth and high social mobility and justice. It can be a difficult balance to strike.

H-1B's death should cheer Indians and Americans

India has nothing to gain from defending a programme that exploits its citizens, discredits their achievements, and harms its own standing

The Trump administration has fired another missile at H-1B, a \$103,265 fee that the courts will likely block. The Indian government may also protest, but it should do the opposite: urge the US to kill the programme altogether.

That is because this deeply flawed visa is hurting Americans, Indian-American, and the perception of India itself.

The US' greatest advantage has always been immigration, and it attracts the world's best minds. Indian engineers and scientists create companies and jobs in the US, make medical and technology breakthroughs, and lead some of the US' largest corporations.

But this isn't because of the H-1B visa; it is despite it.

The H-1B was meant to fill genuine shortages of specialised skills but has become a vehicle for abuse. Indian outsourcing companies turned these visas into a business model. Shoddy boot shops and recruiters continue to manufacture experience and embellish resumes. Many applicants claim skills they do not possess; some simply fake their resumes.

American corporations willingly participate because the arrangement

benefits them. A worker whose immigration status depends on an employer is at its mercy. Visa restrictions make it difficult to change jobs, and accepting a promotion can jeopardise a green-card application or send the worker to the back of the line. So, they don't demand raises, reject assignments, or leave a sub-standard job.

The green-card backlog and per-country limits have turned this into indentured servitude for Indian workers because they have to wait decades for permanent residence. They cling to their jobs praying they don't get laid off. If they are, they have at most 60 days to find another employer or leave the country, abandoning their homes and friends.

Of course, the technology giants lobby only for more H-1B visas, not for the green cards that can free their employees.

The greatest tragedy is what is happening to American workers who have spent decades building their careers. They are mortgaged—children in college, medical bills, and families depending on their salaries. Many are laid off as their employers hire younger workers from India.

A layoff at that stage of life wipes out savings, ends health insurance, and denies their children's education. One of Silicon Valley's darkest secrets is that it discriminates against age for a simple reason: Experienced workers get paid higher salaries.

Displaced Americans are right to be angry. There is real fraud, real labour arbitrage, and real damage to American families. The companies, recruiters and applicants that corrupt the system have earned their wrath. Not surprisingly, this anger spills over onto innocent Indian-Americans. Doctors, scientists, professors, researchers, entrepreneurs, and exceptional engineers who play by the rules and contribute enormously to the US end up as targets of resentment for abuses committed by others.

The attacks move beyond jobs and immigration. Indians are mocked for their accents, food, and culture. Hinduism is ridiculed and vilified and loyalty to the US is questioned. People TCS had roughly 3,000 approvals against a workforce of 585,000. Infosys had just over 3,000 against a workforce of 731,000.

These companies have spent years changing how they operate. They hire more Americans locally, perform more work offshore, and use delivery centres around the world.

The H-1B might raise some costs and disrupt a few projects, but this is minor.

The harsh reality, however, is that the jobs will not return to American workers because they are disappearing altogether. Artificial intelligence is automating the work on which the outsourcing model was built: software testing, maintenance, documentation, and programming itself.

The same technology that allows an Indian outsourcing company to complete a project with fewer engineers in Bengaluru allows an



Vivek Wadhwa

Indian workers feel trapped, and the employers and intermediaries creating the problem gain the benefits.

Why should India defend this? H-1B is like a cancer on the US' skilled-immigration system, hurting American workers, exploiting foreign workers, and rewarding dishonest intermediaries. It is destroying public confidence in skilled immigration.

The H-1B programme should end, and Indians and Americans alike should celebrate its demise.

India need not worry that this will cripple its IT-services industry because dependence on H-1B has



If US tech companies continue eliminating jobs after foreign hiring ends, American politicians will no longer be able to blame Indians. SHUTTERSTOCK

already fallen dramatically. As of March 31, India's six largest IT services companies collectively recorded about 1,000 H-1B approvals, down nearly 40% from a year earlier.

These companies have spent years changing how they operate. They hire more Americans locally, perform more work offshore, and use delivery centres around the world.

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The same technology that allows an Indian outsourcing company to complete a project with fewer engineers in Bengaluru allows an

American corporation to compete with fewer engineers in Boston. A project that once required 100 engineers now requires 30.

The other 70 jobs do not move from India to the US; they vanish. The elimination of these visas will take India out of the line of fire. If technology companies continue eliminating jobs after foreign hiring ends, American politicians will no longer be able to blame Indians. The US will have to confront automation and its own treatment of older, experienced workers. America surely needs to rethink its immigration system so that when it brings in the people it really needs, they are treated as future Americans, not cheap labour. They must be able to change jobs and start companies.

India has nothing to gain from defending a programme that exploits its citizens, discredits their achievements, and harms its own standing.

Vivek Wadhwa is CEO, Vionix Biosciences.

The views expressed are personal

Beijing-Islamabad tango in West Asia mediation

At the recent ASEAN Post-Ministerial Conference in Manila, the foreign ministers of the ten ASEAN countries and China signed a joint statement on the West Asia crisis. While maritime security or supply chain disruptions could have dominated the statement, its most interesting facet was Beijing getting ASEAN to back Pakistan-led mediation in West Asia.

The very first operative assertion of the statement declared ASEAN's support for peace efforts "mediated by the Islamic Republic of Pakistan and the State of Qatar". Even as lip service was paid to "China's effort in putting forth [a] four-point proposal" on peace in the region, this alignment in China and Pakistan's diplomatic language on the war, proudly displayed across many multilateral forums, is something India must watch for at the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Leaders' Summit that is around the corner.

What does Beijing stand to get from promoting the canonisation of Islamabad's mediation efforts? Why put President Xi Jinping's own flagship proposal second, even as it is touted as the way to go in most Chinese foreign ministry briefings?

Broadly, it seems China is attempting to create, to borrow its own words, a "win-win" proposition for itself in the whole ordeal. If a front-and-centre Pakistan remains accountable at every step, the failures will be its own. If it succeeds—which initially seemed to be the case before the conflict restarted after a short pause—the paper trail created both by Beijing and Islamabad ensures the success can be jointly claimed. In essence, for China, Pakistan becomes useful because it is exposed to the consequences of failure.

The first thing China did regarding the US and Israeli strikes, when Iran gained momentum in March, was to quickly attach itself to Pakistan's diplomatic effort. On March 31, Pakistan's deputy prime minister, Ishrat Dar, flew to Beijing, where the two countries issued a five-point plan to restore peace in the Gulf. Subsequently, Pakistan provided a framework for a 45-day ceasefire on April 5, while Xi unveiled his own four-point proposal shortly after. When Chinese foreign minister Wang Yi called his counterpart Dar on April 15, he commended Pakistan for facilitating the temporary ceasefire and for hosting the talks in its capital, praising its "fair and balanced" mediating role. The inflection point came in June, when the US and Iranian presidents signed the Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding, giving both sides 60 days to finalise a pact ending the war. Thereafter, Pakistan led no stone unturned in expressing gratitude to Beijing for its "key role" in facilitating the MoU—including at the SCO Member States' meeting in Kyrgyzstan.

IF PAKISTAN REMAINS ACCOUNTABLE AT EVERY STEP, THE FAILURES WILL BE ITS OWN. IF IT SUCCEEDS, THE PAPER TRAIL CREATED BY BEIJING AND ISLAMABAD ENSURES THE SUCCESS CAN BE JOINTLY CLAIMED

For Beijing, this diplomatic investment creates an incentive structure too good to pass up. Washington and Tehran resumed talks even as Iranian interior minister Iskandar Momeni arrived in Islamabad to meet with mediators. The conflict has since been marked by episodes of escalation and de-escalation, with Washington most recently announcing secondary sanctions that could have devastating economic consequences for Tehran. In the interim, Saudi Arabia joined the US in striking militant groups in Iraq, and the UAE cut all ties with Iran. Moments after the Saudi strikes, visited Islamabad again, indicating its diplomatic corridors to be a preferred force for mediation.

Ever since, Pakistan, along with Qatar, has kept absorbing accountability for the war. Should the mediation continue oscillating or tend towards collapse, the failures will be Islamabad's and Doha's, given that they expended the talks and oversaw the signatures. Beijing's contributions, by contrast, will likely be viewed as principle-based exhortations around sovereignty, dialogue, and peacefulness. And should another ceasefire somehow materialise, Beijing has ensured enough co-borrowing to claim stake and prestige.

But if the design were in place, why would the developments in Manila matter? It is likely that Beijing steering the ASEAN into a joint statement that names Pakistan-Qatar mediation and China's four-point proposal in the same breath—and then pivoting to energy cooperation under Xi's flagship Global Development and Belt and Road Initiatives—gives China to both further its military ambitions and embed its preferred language in an important multilateral consensus document. The fact that conversations among Southeast Asian nations are currently also dominated by tensions between Beijing and the Philippines over the South China Sea almost makes the joint statement a worrying win for the former.

This is not to say Pakistan is merely Beijing's pawn. Islamabad extracted its own gains by expending its mediatory capital. Its leaders seem to have gained genuine leverage in Washington; its image is now popularised as a Versailles in this conflict, and its diplomatic standing has been revitalised just as year after Operation Sindoor. In the same way, China's interest isn't purely reputational as well, given the implications of a closed Strait of Hormuz on its economy and energy mix.

Nonetheless, there are three important takeaways for India. The first is the fact that both its large neighbours and key adversaries are inexplicably tied on all fronts, and Pakistan's image as a State sponsor of terrorism, in particular, is being whitewashed with Beijing's support. The second is what Beijing has achieved vis-à-vis ASEAN: the fact that it is perfecting a carrots-and-sticks template across multilateral groupings, including the SCO and BRICS, can hurt Delhi's own agenda-shaping abilities at these platforms. The third is that even if Pakistan fails as a mediator, India's absence from region-wide diplomacy and peacebuilding processes in West Asia is noticeable and may not play well with actors on whom it depends for much of its energy needs.

Anushka Saxena is associate fellow, The Takshashila Institution. The views expressed are personal

{ LI JIAN } SPOKESPERSON, FOREIGN MINISTRY, CHINA

China... firmly opposes illegal unilateral sanctions... China will take all necessary measures to firmly safeguard its own rights and interests

On the US's economic offensive against Iran



Homeland for Sindhis now exists only in memories

August is a cruel month for the children of Partition. The experience was remembered differently by those who were born in it, in their childhood memories, profiles, Sindhi writer and playwright Mumtaz Mirza recalls. "When we reached school in the morning, our Hindi teacher told us there would be no classes that day. By the next day, he would no longer be our teacher. Now, they will have to leave this country. We have a new country, Pakistan, and they will have to leave for India. After a while, the assembly bell rang, but there were no classes. Instead, we were distributed. We were happy to receive the sweets. At the end, we returned home very happily."

Compared to Punjab, Bengal, Bihar, the North West Frontier Province, the Central Provinces, and the United Provinces, Sindhi initially remained relatively calm. Large-scale violence did not erupt there until early 1948.

Their Sindhi was eventually lost to many Hindus and Sikhs, despite surviving Partition.

For many Sindhi Hindus, however, Sindhi was never the same after January 5, 1948. Violence was reported from Karachi, Hyderabad, Nawabshah and Sukkur, and other parts of the province, following the arrival of large numbers of refugees from Uttar Pradesh, Gujarat, and Rajasthan. Everyone wanted to go to the land of their ancestors. Many were told to abandon their homeland. Was Dada Tharwadars Laram Vaswani, a revered educationist, philanthropist, mystic, scholar, and spiritual leader. He had established the Miran Girls' High School in Hyderabad. After Partition, Vaswani reportedly advised his disciples to remain in Sindhi and serve the land in which they had been born. Many followed his advice.

On September 11, 1948, after learning of the death of Mohammed Ali Jinnah, founder of Pakistan, Vaswani observed a *vrat* (fast), and recited the Quran. At the *vrat*'s conclusion, he distributed sweets among fellow worshippers, as was customary in his religious practice. Some people, however, spread the rumour that he had distributed sweets to celebrate Jinnah's death.

Home became dangerous overnight. Vaswani was reportedly told by authorities that he must either leave for India or risk detention under the inherited colonial laws. Similar pressure was faced by writers, artists, and political activists, including Gohad Mahi, Kirat Bahani, AK Hangal, and Hashoo Kevaramani. Some, including Sobho Gianchandani and Pophomal Mahi, refused to leave and accepted the possibility of imprisonment. Hangal was jailed and eventually fled.

There was also the case of Parcho Vidyarthi, who had been involved in radical politics aimed at ending British rule. He was imprisoned on charges connected with violence against British officials and property, and later escaped and fled to India. There, he was recognised at the state level as a freedom fighter, although the Centre reportedly declined to recognise him because his identity could not be established.

Homes were lost but the pain is preserved in memories of Sindhis. "On January 17, 1948, my father's family was on a train to Ahmedabad. When my grandmother went into labour they had to change trains at Marwar Junction to Jodhpur to get to a hospital," recalls my friend and London-based poet and author Rishika Williams. "My mother's family left on a goods train at night. She was free. Her parents filled gold coins inside an empty Triple S cigarette tin and gave it to her, hoping officials would not be likely to search a small child. The family eventually reached The White Shop on Mount Road in Madras, which they owned."

She also recalls that the daughter of an accountant, who tried to help her paternal grandfather, was reportedly gang-raped. That is when her grandfather decided to send his family to India.

Williams was born in Nigeria and raised in London. Her father moved from Sindhi to India to work for his uncles in Hong Kong and Japan before he opened businesses in Cameroon and Nigeria. Sindhi remains central to her poetry—a homeland inherited that she carries with her. A similar inherited memory lives in another friend—filmmaker and celebrity hairstylist Sapna Moti Bhavnani—who heard stories of Sindhi from her maternal grandmother. She sports tattoos connected to Sindhi and made the film, *Sindhistan*, portraying the province and the trauma of losing a homeland. She has expressed a desire to visit Sindhi, but says she was denied a visa. Through her tattoos, she says, she has, in a sense, become Sindhi herself. Her poem *When a Sindhi Woman Dies, So Does a Book* captures the idea of a homeland preserved not on a map but within the body.

They often ask me where I'm from. I gather my dress, and underneath a lost homeland in place of bone.

The poem transforms memory into an archive of a homeland carried through generations, even after borders have made return difficult or impossible.

Hasan Mujtaba is a poet, journalist, and human rights defender. The views expressed are personal

Iran ties: Xi signals defiance as America threatens sanctions

Bloomberg & Reuters
letters@hindustantimes.com

BEIJING: Xi Jinping's government is sending a message of defiance to Donald Trump over China's economic ties with Iran. Beijing responded by saying its relationship with Iran "should not be disrupted or undermined". China will take "all necessary measures" to safeguard its interests, foreign ministry spokesperson Lin Jian warned.

The response underscores the risk of another clash between the superpowers as Trump promotes an economic onslaught against Iran in a bid to pressure the Islamic Republic into a deal.

China has thrown Tehran an economic lifeline as its biggest buyer of oil, and Xi appears in no rush to help Trump end a conflict that's pulling US resources from Asia while giving him more bargaining power before a leaders' summit next month. For the US, taking action against any major Chinese bank supporting Iran's wartime economy would invite bigger blowback from its Asian rival.

China wants the conflict contained, but it has little reason to help Trump end it without receiving something in return," said Jesse Marks, founder of Rihla Research & Advisory, a former Middle East policy adviser in the US government.

For Xi, there are benefits to Trump being focused on Iran. The US this month redeployed its lone Asia-based aircraft carrier to the Middle East, while American forces later announced they were scrapping an exercise with South Korea over shortages related to deployments to the region around



A still image released by Iranian media on Monday shows Mojtaba Khamenei attending a meeting before he assumed the role of Iran's Supreme Leader, at an unknown location. REUTERS

STRAIT OF HORMUZ DEMINED: TRUMP

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump said on Tuesday that all mines had been detonated or removed from international waters of the Strait of Hormuz and that Iran has been told that any ship or boat placing new mines will be destroyed.

In a post on Truth Social, Trump said the United States, through its Space Force, was watching "every square inch" of the Strait, a key waterway in the global energy supply chain. REUTERS

Iran. That could give China a freer hand as it continues to assert its territorial claims in the South China Sea and around self-ruled Taiwan.

While Xi won't cut ties with Tehran, Beijing could decide to further reduce purchases of Iranian oil or keep income from such transactions locked in Chinese banks, Marks said. Tightening tighter controls on Chinese-made dual-use components that could reach Iranian weapons programmes is another option ahead

of the summit. Ignoring Washington completely could antagonise the US leader weeks before the September 24 meeting in Washington designed to preserve a trade truce between the world's biggest economies. Ahead of that showdown, China is already buying less discounted Iranian crude, as the US naval blockade squeezes supply.

Iran vows to resist expanded sanctions

Iran pledged on Tuesday to fight back against expanded US sanctions aimed at isolating its economy, expressing confidence that major trading partners would resist the pressure campaign and saying that Washington was keen to revive talks. Iran expressed a general willingness to resume peace talks during meetings between Iranian and Pakistani officials on Monday, while expressing concern about the sanctions, a Pakistani government source said. "Pakistan told them the US will reverse those decisions either before, or during a new round of negotiations," the official said.

U.S. SANCTIONS FOUR INDIA-BASED COMPANIES FOR IMPORTING IRANIAN OIL PRODUCTS

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: The US has sanctioned four India-based companies for importing petroleum and petrochemical products from Iran, according to a press release issued by the US State Department. US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent on Monday announced "Operation Economic Outcast", which aims to block all potential sources of revenue for Iran. The US has also told countries to cut economic ties with Tehran or face retaliation.

Among the four "India-based companies" facing action is a customs broker identified as Portese Partners LLP and its partners Indrisimya Ashrafmiya Sheikh and Harish Ramachandra Rang. They facilitated the import of multiple shipments of Iranian petrochemical products, the State Department said.

Other Indian companies facing action are Sadashiva Overseas Limited; PP Softtech Private Limited, along with its director Prashant Garg; and Prakrutesh Infra Impex Private Limited.

Sheikh, Rang and Garg are Indian nationals, according to the release. Sadashiva Overseas imported Iranian-origin petroleum products worth around \$69 million from multiple companies, while PP Softtech and Prakrutesh Infra imported petroleum products worth \$25 million each, the press release said. These companies were put on a list for "knowingly engaging in a significant transaction for the purchase, acquisition, sale, transport, or marketing of petroleum or petroleum products from Iran," it said.

State Department spokesperson Tommy Pigott said, "Today, the US took action against multiple entities, individuals, and vessels enabling the Iranian regime's destabilising activities. Such activities include attacks against the sanctions, a Pakistani government source said. "Pakistan told them the US will reverse those decisions either before, or during a new round of negotiations," the official said.

Canada strikes back with 15-50% tariffs on US goods

Reuters, AFP & AP
letters@hindustantimes.com

OTTAWA: Canada on Tuesday announced retaliatory tariffs on US goods worth \$27.6 billion (\$19.94 billion) worth of United States goods, matching dollar-for-dollar new duties imposed by Washington, and unveiled financial support for Canadian businesses and workers caught in the escalating trade war.

The counter-tariffs take effect on US goods from September 8 and will impose duties of 15%, 25% and 50% across 700 products imported from south of the border, a government statement said.

Under Canada's planned response, US steel and aluminium products previously subject to a 25% duty will soon face 50% tariffs. Goods facing 25% tariffs will include appliances, dairy products like cheese, as well as certain steel and aluminium derivative products. A small cat-

Trump threatens to change name of Lake Ontario to Lake America

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump said on Tuesday that he was considering changing the name of Lake Ontario to "Lake America". The US is giving serious consideration to changing the name of Lake Ontario to Lake America in that we don't expect to doing much business with Ontario any longer," Trump wrote in a post on Truth Social. REUTERS

egory will see a 15% duty, including electric equipment and tools. Overall, these form about

7.3% of Canada's imports from the United States.

From Saturday, US President Donald Trump's new 50% tariffs across \$20 billion of Canadian imports took effect after talks between the two countries to avert the tariffs collapsed.

The new 10-for-10 tariff marks a new low in the Canada-US relationship. "Our dollar-for-dollar, rate for rate counter-tariffs as well as a multi-billion dollar support package will protect workers, farmers, families, and businesses," Canada's Finance Minister Francois-Philippe Champagne said.

President Trump intensified the confrontation on Monday, telling Canadian leaders to "fall in line" or face consequences "far WORSE" than existing tariffs and threatening new 50% tariffs on Canadian vehicles, auto parts and steel.

CIA chief visits Russia; Ukraine, Iran wars may have figured in talks

WASHINGTON/MOSCOW: US CIA director John Ratcliffe travelled to Moscow on Tuesday for meetings with Russian officials, US media outlets reported, citing unnamed sources.

The visit would be the first by a US spy chief since Ratcliffe's predecessor, William Burns, held talks with Vladimir Putin in November 2021. About three months after that meeting, the Russian president launched Moscow's invasion of Ukraine.

Data from tracking site Flight-radar24 had earlier shown a US military C-17 Globemaster III plane travelling from the United States to Latvia and then on to Moscow's Vnukovo airport. The data showed the same plane leaving Moscow several hours later.

The US has no ambassador to Russia, which maintains a close strategic partnership with Iran involving extensive military, economic and diplomatic ties. Ratcliffe's visit comes as US-brokered talks aimed at ending Russia's invasion of Ukraine have stalled. But Moscow earlier this month freed a former US Marine detained since 2022.

The Iran war is also a live issue between Washington and Tehran's ally Moscow.

Tehran supplied Moscow with drones for its war against Ukraine. In March, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy accused Russia of supplying its version of those drones to Iran. The data showed the same plane leaving

US prepares to revoke up to 200K foreigners' visas

Associated Press
letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: The Trump administration is preparing to revoke the business and tourism visas of up to 200,000 foreigners who have applied for or are currently seeking asylum status in the United States. If it happens, the move would be the largest single mass revocation of visas in US history and would likely face legal challenges.

Unless challenged or revised, the State Department is expected to announce in the coming weeks the revocation of so-called B1 and B2 visas issued between 2016 and 2026 whose holders have sought asylum or are now seeking asylum, according to State Department documents obtained by The Associated Press and two US officials. The

B'DESH PLANS TO BUY CHINESE JETS IN MILITARY OVERHAUL

DHAKA: Bangladesh is advancing plans to purchase Chinese J-10CE fighter jets, with a government official pointing to the aircraft's performance in the recent India-Pakistan conflict.

A government negotiation committee has finalised a draft contract for the procurement of the multi-role combat aircraft, Zuhair Rahman, adviser to the prime minister for policy, strategy and information, said at a media briefing in Dhaka on Tuesday.

The purchase plan is part of a wider military modernisation initiative. Rahman did not disclose the number of jets being sought or their price in his briefing.

The procurement plan also includes attack helicopters for the Bangladesh Air Force, along with VIP helicopters and unmanned aerial vehicle systems, according to the adviser.

"If funds are available this fiscal year, the plans will move forward; otherwise, they will be pushed to the next budget cycle," he said. BLOOMBERG

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Foreign investors buy ₹25K-cr Indian equities in 23-month high

Abhinaba Saha
abhinaba.saha@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) are returning to India, but the buying is far from a broad vote of confidence.

FPIs invested over ₹25,000 crore in Indian stocks between August 1 and 24, the strongest monthly inflow since September 2024, after bringing ₹20,200 crore in July. If the trend holds, FPIs will have bought Indian equities for two consecutive months for the first time this year—a sharp reversal from the record monthly outflow of nearly ₹12 trillion in March.

Yet, global fund managers remain wary, as India became Asia's least-preferred equity market in Bank of America's August fund manager survey.

The disconnect signals FPIs are rebuilding exposure to parts of the market where recent corrections have improved valuations and earnings visibility, rather than making a broad bet on India. Their choices reflect uncertainty over global growth, bond-market returns and the AI

Buying streak

If the trend holds, foreign investors will have bought Indian equities for two consecutive months for the first time this year.

Monthly foreign portfolio investor flows, in ₹ crore



*Latest data available till 24 Aug
Source: NDA

Graphic: Satish Kumar/Mint

trade even as domestic earnings hold up.

Financial services drew the most FPI money in the first fortnight of August, attracting ₹5,535 crore after an outflow of ₹2,669 crore in the previous fortnight, per National Securities Depository Ltd data. Auto-

biles followed with ₹4,405 crore, nearly twice the inflow in the second half of July, while consumer services attracted ₹3,398 crore, up from ₹2,840 crore in the previous fortnight.

These are sectors foreign investors traditionally favour, and recent corrections have

improved their risk-reward equation, said Divam Sharma, cofounder, Green Portfolio PMS. The Nifty Financial Services index trades at 17.3 times 12-month trailing earnings, below its five-year average of 19.5 times. The Nifty Auto index trades at 33.6 times, against an average of 41.8 times, while the Nifty Consumption index is at 42.3 times, below its 47.2-times average. The Nifty 50 trades at 21.8 times earnings, below its five-year average of 23.1 times, suggesting the valuation reset is making parts of the market more attractive.

The contrast is clearest in the sectors losing foreign money. Capital goods, power and realty saw some of the strongest FPI outflows between August 1 and 15, while telecom led the decline with an outflow of ₹3,322 crore.

Telecom, power and capital goods have also seen consistent outflows for nearly two months, signalling a shift away from overvalued and rate-sensitive businesses towards companies with greater earnings and demand visibility.

The prospect of persistently higher borrowing costs is a key driver of this sectoral rotation, said Harsh Gupta Madhusudan, fund manager of Ionic Asset's PIPE Fund.

On August 18, the 30-year US Treasury yield hit 5.34%, the highest since 2007, as investors dumped US bonds after its debt breached \$40 trillion. The sell-off reflected growing concerns over the sustainability of America's fiscal position and raised global long-term bond yields.

Meanwhile, some of India's capex and cyclical stocks have risen sharply in recent months, making their valuations less compelling, Gupta added. The Nifty Infrastructure index trades at 24.4 times 12-month trailing earnings, slightly above its five-year average of 23.8 times.

Foreign investors have there- fore gravitated towards businesses with relatively predictable domestic demand. Domestic urban consumption is also benefit- ing from global capability centre expansion, while govern- ment subsidy spending supports rural activity, Gupta said.

Committee backs firm's Gurugram power supply bid

Hittender Rao

letters@hindustantimes.com

CHANDIGARH: An expert committee set up by the Haryana Electricity Regulatory Commission (HERC) to examine Eleven Power Pvt. Ltd.'s petition for a parallel electricity distribution licence in Gurugram and Nuh districts has recommended that the licence be granted, subject to conditions.

State-owned power distribution company Dakshin Haryana Bijli Vitran Nigam (DHBVN) currently serves electricity consumers exclusively in the two districts. Eleven Power, a private company incorporated in 2025, has Sunil Sachdeva, co-founder of Medanta-The Medicity, a chain of multi-specialty hospitals, as its director. Sachdeva is also chairman of the Eleven Group.

The panel, headed by retired IAS officer Alok Nigam, said in its report submitted to the Commission that it had found no ground on which Eleven Power's petition should be refused.

"The Committee accordingly recommends that a parallel distribution licence may be considered for grant to the applicant, subject to the conditions suggested in Schedules A to D. The matters requiring regulatory attention relate to implementation, sequencing and continuing supervision, and the Committee has recommended licence conditions and safeguards through which these may be addressed," the report said.

The report is recommendatory in nature.

However, power engineers' bodies have challenged the committee's recommendations, raising questions over whether a new licensee can meet the statutory universal supply obligation (USO) while building its network in phases.

Representatives of power engineers' bodies, which are intervenors in the petition, have questioned whether the expert panel adequately tested the com-



The report is recommendatory in nature.

MINT

patibility of Eleven Power's phased, demand-driven model with the statutory obligation to serve the entire licensed area under the USO.

Eleven Power has committed to invest about ₹4,716 crore over five years, from 2026-27 to 2030-31, with 84% of its five-year capital expenditure planned for the final three years. The expert panel accepted the phased investment plan despite DHBVN's contention that ₹1,307 crore would be needed to create infrastructure capable of meeting the USO across the two districts.

Rejecting DHBVN's argument, the panel treated the two estimates as being based on different approaches to network development, with Eleven Power proposing a phased, demand-linked rollout.

"What happens if consumer migration is much faster than anticipated by the private player? The concept of universal service obligation is enshrined under Section 43 of the Electricity Act, which places a statutory obligation on every energy supply area to serve all consumers in its area without discrimination. A central point of DHBVN's objections to Eleven Power's bid is the USO. The private company needs to have complete infrastructure. There cannot be a phased investment plan. We will contest the capital adequacy," said Puneet Kundra, president of the Haryana Power Engineers Association.

HC RESTRAINS FSSAI FROM CANCELLING ITC'S FOOD BIZ LICENCE

Shruti Kakkar

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Tuesday restrained the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) from taking any decision to cancel ITC Ltd's food business licence over its use of the claims "100% Atta", "100% Madhya Pradesh Wheat" and "0% Maida" for Aashirvaad MP Chakki Atta.

A bench of Justices Swarnima Kanta Sharma issued the direction, observing that the question of whether the high court had territorial jurisdiction to examine ITC's challenge to the notices dated August 10 and August 13 was yet to be decided, but it was closed from August 26 to August 30. It further noted that ITC was required to respond to the FSSAI's August 13 notice by August 28, failing which its licence would be cancelled.

The FSSAI on August 10 had issued a show cause notice alleging that ITC had violated FSSAI's May 2025 advisory asking food businesses to discontinue the use of "100%" on product labels, packaging and promotional material. It had asked ITC to clarify as to why action must not be initiated against it under the provisions of the Food Safety and Standards (FSS) Act, 2006 and rules and regulations within 30 days.

Three days later, FSSAI's regional authority Kolkata issued another notice directing ITC Ltd to remove the claims "100% Atta", "100% Madhya Pradesh Wheat" and "0% Maida" for Aashirvaad MP Chakki Atta across all the labels in 15 days.

It said that failure to do so would result in serious consequences including withdrawal of existing packaging and stock, delisting of the product from e-commerce platforms and also threatened to suspend the company's central licence which would prevent it from suspension of carrying out of its food products.

Strategic shift propels market cap of CPSEs

Saubhadra Chatterjee & Rajeev Jayaswal

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The government's strategy of moving from a revenue-centric annual disinvestment target to value maximisation through prudent public asset management has seen an over three-and-a-half-fold jump in market capitalisation of central public sector companies from ₹42.76 lakh crore in February 2022 to ₹121 lakh crore in March 2021, according to government data.

Fixing separate disinvestment targets was discontinued

from financial year 2023-24," a finance ministry official who did not wish to be named, said.

In an interview with HT on February 7, 2024, then Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (DIPAM) secretary Tuhin Kant Pandey explained the policy shift from pursuing a numerical goal because disinvestment proceeds were no longer critical for meeting the annual fiscal deficit target.

The parliamentary committee on finance, chaired by BJP lawmaker Bharturhari Mahtab, appreciated the strategic shift in its report published this month.



The government is focused on value maximisation.

AFP

of listed CPSEs—from ₹12.10 lakh crore in 2021 to ₹42.76 lakh crore in early 2026—and a 174% increase in net profits per CPSE over five years," it added. Members of the panel included veteran opposition leaders like NK Premchandran, Sougata Ray and Manish Tewari from Lok Sabha, and P Chidambaram, Pratul Patel, and Pramod Tiwari from Rajya Sabha. In the same period, the benchmark Sensex index returned 64.2%.

Talking about the change in DIPAM's strategy with HT in an interview, Pandey said that earlier people used to focus only on disinvestment while ignoring

huge wealth creation by public sector enterprises, reflected under head of dividends and profits. "So, in our new paradigm, we are having integrated and holistic approach," he said.

The focus of the government is on maximisation of overall value of public sector enterprises (PSEs) rather than a providing specific disinvestment target in the budget to place market analysts, a second official said, requesting anonymity. A beginning was made in the revised estimates of 2023-24, which did not show any specific number for disinvestment in 2023-24 and the trend continued, he added.

U'KHAND INKS POWER PURCHASE PACT WITH ADANI

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

DEHRADUN: The Uttarakhand cabinet on Tuesday approved the purchase of 1,320 MW of coal-based power from Adani Power Ltd at a tariff of ₹5.746 per unit for 25 years, the government said, adding that Adani Power was the lowest bidder. The purchase includes 1,234 MW of contracted capacity and aims to ensure a reliable base-load power supply and energy security in the state.

The cabinet, chaired by chief minister Pushkar Singh Dhami, also authorised Uttarakhand Power Corporation Ltd (UPL) to sign the power supply agreement with Adani Power, and complete the required formalities, subject to statutory approvals from the Uttarakhand Electricity Regulatory Commission.

AIR INDIA SEEKS \$1.5 BN FROM TATA, SIA AMID LOSSES

Reuters

feedback@hivemint.com

NEW DELHI: Air India is seeking about \$1.5 billion in fresh equity from its owners Tata Sons and Singapore Airlines, months after the Indian airline posted a record annual loss, two people familiar with the matter said.

It would be one of Air India's largest publicly reported requests for shareholder funding since Tata took control of the former state-owned carrier in 2022. It highlights the challenges facing the airline as it undergoes a multi-billion-dollar revamp, including the refurbishment of its existing fleet. The carrier and its budget unit Air India Express posted combined losses of \$2.33 billion in the fiscal year ended March, more than double the prior year's losses.

It is seeking the funding in the form of fresh equity, the two people said. Discussions are ongoing and no decision has been taken on the request, they added, declining to be named as they were not authorised to discuss the matter publicly.

Air India and Tata Sons did not respond to Reuters requests for comment.

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

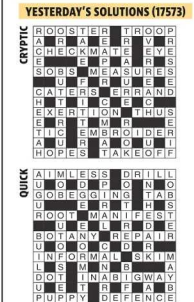
CRYPTIC CLUES

- ACROSS**
- The larger to change to on the whole (10)
 - Dispute in banks (4)
 - Don't argue (5)
 - Out to make one uneasy? (3,2,4)
 - When the capital is in alliance to Paraguay's (8)
 - Well salted (5)
 - Not impressed (7)
 - The head cleaner? (7)
 - No gentleman loses his life on the golf course (10)
 - I am upmost in his thoughts (7)
 - Nick's not at church (5)
 - Refinements of elegant newwear (8)
 - Not impressed (9)
 - Money one may charge in Africa (5)
 - Such a fuss getting to the party (2-2)
 - An armed timing device? (10)

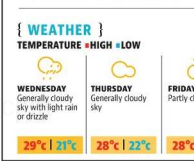
DOWN

- Whisper's cry of surprise touches sailor (4)
- A carry-over of marriage ritual (9)
- It's for putting on colour (5)
- Punishment for living in the sun? (7)
- Name in literature can case holds out? (7)
- Do come up with our bouquet (5)
- Fast transport to be passed with difficulty (10)
- Brief notes jazz fans sent up to the censor (8)
- Give the players the wrong time? (10)
- Whiskey starts machine operator in lively dance (5,3)
- Bill is brought to heel by what things cost (5,4)
- US politician who could resort to treason? (7)
- Create a secret passage? (7)
- Largely drink up a store of supplies (5)
- It's worth having a change so have a fling (5)
- His vessel had a full complement of mates (4)

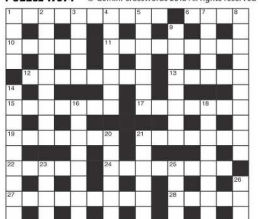
YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17573)



QUICK



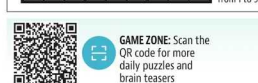
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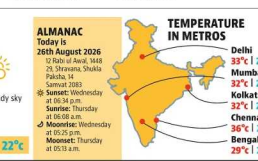
QUICK CLUES

- ACROSS**
- Let slip an opportunity (4,3,3)
 - Play the lead (4)
 - Item (5)
 - Enchant (9)
 - Kind of scorching weather (10)
 - Rouse (5)
 - Trudge wearily (7)
 - Put up with (7)
 - To gorge (7)
 - In succession (7)
 - A kind (5)
 - Boundless extent of time (8)
 - Make publicly known (9)
 - A tenth part (5)
 - Up to the time of (4)
 - No longer useful (2,3,5)
- DOWN**
- To dispense (4)
 - Enrich (9)
 - Enrich (9)
 - To trap (7)
 - Unaffected (7)
 - Special technique (5)
 - Enjoying run of success (6,4)
 - Ridder speed (4,4)
 - After much delay (2,4,4)
 - Force exerted (5)
 - Greek philosopher and scientist (9)
 - Schooling (7)
 - Reverry (7)
 - Work of fiction (5)
 - Memoir (5)
 - With impaired hearing (4)

{ SUDOKU }



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READ EVERY SUNDAY

How tactical predictability and defensive disarray hurt India

Sandip Sikdar

sandip.sikdar@htlive.com

NEW DELHI: The wait for a World Cup medal rolls on, extending the grim reality check for Indian hockey. Despite heading into the quadrennial showcase with some confidence, India's campaign collapsed under the weight of defensive frailties and tactical predictability.

While routine victories over lower-ranked Wales and Pakistan provided a false sense of momentum, India were comprehensively dismantled by the three elite teams they faced: the Netherlands (3-1), England (4-2), and Argentina. The final nail in the coffin, a 5-3 defeat to Argentina, encapsulated everything that went wrong.

It wasn't a case of India being outclassed by dazzling, unplayable hockey; rather, the downfall was self-inflicted—born out of defensive disarray and a glaring inability to control the tempo of high-stakes matches. Conceding 16 goals in five matches is alarming enough, but the fact that 12 of those were field goals exposed the problems in India's defensive structure. In modern hockey, where fast transitions and 3D skills dictate the pace, relying on a leaky backline is a death sentence.

The defence failed not necessarily due to a radical change in style but because of a breakdown in basics—man-to-man marking, positional awareness and communication.

Defending is a collective responsibility that starts from the front. However, when the initial press was bypassed, the Indian defence was frequently caught ball-watching, allowing unmarked attackers to penetrate the circle.

Against Argentina and Netherlands, the gaps between the mid-field and defence were regularly exploited, forcing the defenders into reactive and panicked tackles. "Our marking was loose especially against the Netherlands and Argentina. I know the boys are putting in the effort but these small things are where we are behind and need to overcome," former India skipper Sardar Singh told HT. "There was no clear communication too in defence. The homework needs to be better. Of course, the coach will strategise



India at the World Cup



but it is you who has to execute."

Against Argentina, India found themselves 0-2 down within six minutes on Monday. While they managed to claw back to 1-2 by half-time, the third quarter saw India lose their grip.

"Disappointing," India chief coach Craig Fulton said. "We didn't want the start. The third quarter was a little hard to manage, we didn't play our normal fast-attacking hockey."

A significant tactical vulnerability was India's over-reliance on captain Harmanpreet Singh. His drag-flick is world-class but elite teams have learned to neutralise

India's penalty corner routines. When the first rusher charges down, India's secondary options, variation or second battery, often look uncoordinated. When the PCs dried up, India's Plan B was practically non-existent. The strikers showed lack of patience when entering the circle, often rushing the final pass or taking low-percentage shots instead of creating a PC or clear scoring chances.

The midfield struggled to feed the forwards cleanly, leaving Harmanpreet to shoulder a difficult burden. When a team relies so heavily on a single drag-flicker to bail them out, opponents simply

focus on defending the circle cleanly and cutting off supply lines. While tactical adjustments can solve short-term issues, the root cause of India's struggles against top opposition lies deeper.

"It's not a problem of players but of the system. We do not have a pool of 200-400 players but only of about 50. We need their replacements but we don't have them," former India skipper Pargat Singh told HT.

"In my opinion, England probably has the weakest structure among the top European nations but even they have multiple levels of structured league system going

down to the grassroots. Let us not even discuss the Dutch structure as they are way ahead."

"Until we fix the structural issues we are not going to move ahead. From solving the problem of age fudging to having more All India tournaments like in the past, it is a long road ahead. We developed a group of 10-15 players who went on and won two Olympic medals and when they phase out, our hockey will go down again. It is a structural problem."

Until the issues are resolved quickly, the wait for that elusive World Cup medal will only stretch longer.

Alonso's Chelsea off to a winning start

LONDON: Xabi Alonso hailed Chelsea's special forwards after Morgan Rogers, Cole Palmer and Joao Pedro combined to inspire a 3-2 win at Fulham on Monday in his first game as Blues boss.

Alonso enjoyed the perfect start to his reign thanks to his decision to give Rogers, Palmer and Pedro the freedom to tear into Fulham's defence. Pedro took just 31 seconds

to open the scoring with a composed finish from Palmer's pass. Rogers showed he can justify the eye-watering £17 million (\$19 million) fee that Chelsea paid to Aston Villa to make him the most expensive British player in history.

The England star bagged Chelsea's second goal, firing home with aplomb after Fulham had punished a mistake from Blues goal-

keeper Robert Sanchez to equalise through Josh King. And Palmer joined the party after half-time, scoring from an acute angle to put Chelsea 3-1 up.

"We were a threat. The three strikers were combining well," Alonso said. "It's a good start. But it is not to rely only on them. We need to have control, quality and toughness."

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